AYURVEDIC DRAVYA & AUSHADHA

A Reference-Style Herb & Medicine Monograph Collection

Botanical identity • Traditional context • Constituents • Evidence • Forms • Safety

Purpose & scope

An educational reference to selected Ayurvedic herbs and medicinal substances. Traditional uses are distinguished from clinical evidence where possible. Common names may refer to different species, and product identity, preparation, and quality matter.

IMPORTANT MEDICAL DISCLAIMER

This publication is for education only, not a prescribing guide or substitute for medical care. Do not self-treat with toxic plants or unverified preparations. Suspected poisoning requires urgent emergency/poison-service advice. Consult qualified healthcare professionals about individual use, interactions, pregnancy, breastfeeding, and children.

Deep green, saffron and cream • A4 format • Unicode-safe embedded fonts

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HERBS (DRAVYA)

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DEFINITION AND SCOPE

Dravya is the substance or material basis of a therapeutic agent in Ayurveda. A medicinal plant entry includes its authenticated botanical identity,
used part, classical properties, actions, indications, preparation forms, and safety. This section includes single herbs and their relevant plant parts; it
distinguishes species and common-name confusions rather than treating similar names as identical.

RASA–GUNA–VRYA–VIPKA–PRABHVA

Rasa is the taste perceived initially; Guna describes qualities such as heavy/light or oily/dry; Vīrya is the principal potency, commonly described as
heating or cooling; Vipāka is the post-digestive effect; Prabhāva denotes a specific action not adequately explained by the other categories.

Interpretations should follow the cited classical source.

HOW HERBS ARE CLASSIFIED

Dravya may be grouped by botanical identity and plant part, habitat, taste and qualities, therapeutic karma, or classical gana/varga. Nighaṇṭus
organize materia medica into named groups; groupings and synonyms may differ by text. Authentication, correct plant part, processing, dose form
and quality are essential.

READING THE ENTRIES

Classical indications describe traditional use, not proof of clinical effectiveness. Modern evidence is labelled traditional, preclinical or clinical. “Data
not established” means that a dependable, species-specific claim was not confirmed for this edition. Do not substitute one species or plant part for
another based on a shared vernacular name.

CORE REFERENCE FRAMEWORK

Use the Ayurvedic Pharmacopoeia of India (API) for identity, purity and quality standards; the Ayurvedic Formulary of India (AFI) for official
formulation recipes where applicable; classical Saṃhitās and Nighaṇṭus for textual context; and systematic reviews/clinical trials for modern
evidence. Edition, volume and plant part should be recorded.

QUICK FACTS

Safety principle: A classical use is not an instruction for self-treatment. Toxic plants, pregnancy, children, chronic illness and prescription medicines
require specialist review.

Avagandh | Ashwagandha

Hindi: Ashwagandha Gujarati: Asgandh Botanical: Withania somnifera (L.) Dunal Family: Solanaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE

Avagandh is a perennial shrub; its dried root is the principal classical Ayurvedic drug. It is traditionally described as a balya and rasyana dravya. The name is commonly interpreted as “smell of a horse,” though this is a traditional etymology, not a proven botanical derivation. Nighaṇṭu synonyms include Avagandh, Vjigandh and Hayagandh. Scope: chiefly root; leaf-containing extracts are not interchangeable with root drugs. Available as chra, decoction, extract and compound preparations; confirm species and plant part.

QUICK FACTS

Dry regions and cultivated fields across India; also found in parts of Africa and the Middle East. Rasa: tikta, kaya (descriptions vary); Guna: laghu, snigdha; Vīrya: ua; Vipāka: madhura. Dosha: traditionally Vāta-Kapha maka; use cautiously where Pitta aggravation is a concern. Karma: balya, bhaa, rasyana (classical descriptions).

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Charaka: rasyana and balya context is discussed in classical tradition; exact chapter-specific mention should be checked against a critical edition.

Bhvapraka Nighaṇṭu: Avagandhdi varga. API: Avagandh root monograph (Part I, Vol. I; 1986).

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Withanolides (including withaferin A in some plant parts), withanosides, sitoindosides and alkaloids; levels vary by plant part and extract.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNAT)

Traditionally used for weakness, convalescence and Vāta-related complaints; also used in formulations for sleep and stress. These are traditional indications, not proof of cure.

WHY USE IT? / MAIN BENEFITS

May support stress management and sleep for some people; results depend on extract and study design. It is not a substitute for diagnosis or treatment.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Small clinical trials suggest some preparations may improve perceived stress and insomnia; studies are heterogeneous and long-term safety is uncertain. Evidence for many other claims remains insufficient.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Forms: root chra, kvtha and standardized extracts. A universal API dose is not asserted here: API monographs primarily set identity/quality standards; dose depends on preparation and clinical context. Use a practitioner-prescribed dose.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Avagandh cra, Avagandhria, Bal-Avagandhdi taila (formulae differ by text/manufacturer).

SAFETY & CAUTIONS

Avoid during pregnancy; breastfeeding safety is insufficiently established. Possible drowsiness, gastrointestinal upset and rare liver injury reports.

May affect thyroid function and interact with thyroid, diabetes, blood-pressure, sedative, anticonvulsant and immunosuppressant medicines. Discuss before surgery.

Sources: PCIM&H;/API Avagandh monograph; NCCIH, “Ashwagandha: Usefulness and Safety” (accessed 2026).

Nimba | Neem

English: Neem / Indian lilac Hindi: Neem Gujarati: Limdo Botanical: Azadirachta indica A. Juss. Family: Meliaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE

Nimba is a tropical evergreen tree used in Ayurveda as a bitter, traditionally cleansing and skin-oriented dravya. The Sanskrit name Nimba is
established in the materia medica; a precise literal etymology is not asserted here. Nighaṇṭu paryya include Aria and Piumarda in some
lexicons. Scope includes leaf, bark, seed and seed oil, which have different chemistry and safety profiles. It appears as leaf powder, decoction,
topical preparations and medicated oils; neem oil must not be treated as equivalent to leaf medicine.

QUICK FACTS

Native to the Indian subcontinent and widely cultivated in tropical/subtropical regions. Rasa: tikta, kaya; Guna: laghu, ruka; Vīrya: ta
(commonly described); Vipāka: kau. Dosha: traditionally Kapha-Pitta maka; may increase Vāta when used excessively. Karma: kuhaghna,
krimighna and kandughna in classical descriptions.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Bhvapraka Nighaṇṭu: Nimba varga; Dhanvantari Nighaṇṭu contains Nimba entries. Classical use varies by plant part; verify the specific
edition before assigning a chapter citation.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Limonoids (including azadirachtin, especially in seeds), nimbin, nimbolide and other phenolics; composition differs across leaf, bark and seed.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNAT)

Traditionally applied in skin disorders, itching and wound-care contexts; leaf and bark preparations are also described for fever and intestinal
parasites in traditional sources.

WHY USE IT? / MAIN BENEFITS

Topical preparations may have antimicrobial activity in laboratory studies, but clinical benefits depend on formulation and condition. “Natural” does
not mean harmless.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Mostly preclinical and small/limited clinical studies; robust evidence for treating systemic disease is lacking. Neem oil ingestion has caused serious
poisoning, particularly in children.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Leaf chra/kvtha and topical forms are described traditionally. A universal dose is not provided because API identity standards do not establish a
single therapeutic dose for all parts and products. Do not ingest neem oil.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Nimbdi cra and Nimbdi taila names are used for different formulae; check the exact classical or licensed product composition.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS

Avoid medicinal-dose use in pregnancy unless specifically supervised; safety in lactation is insufficiently established. Neem oil can cause vomiting,
seizures, metabolic acidosis and encephalopathy. Possible glucose-lowering interactions; avoid unsupervised internal use in children or people with
liver/kidney disease.

Sources: Bhvapraka Nighaṇṭu; Dhanvantari Nighaṇṭu; PCIM&H;/API monographs where available; published toxicology reviews.

Haridrā | Turmeric

English: Turmeric Hindi: Haldi Gujarati: Haldar Botanical: Curcuma longa L. (syn. C. domestica Valeton) Family: Zingiberaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE

Haridrā is a rhizomatous perennial herb whose dried rhizome is used as a culinary spice and Ayurvedic dravya. The name is associated with its
yellow colour. Nighaṇṭu synonyms include Ni, Kñcan and Varavarin in traditional lists. Scope: mainly dried rhizome; wild turmeric (C. aromatica) is a distinct species and not automatically interchangeable. Forms include powder, decoction, paste, medicated oil and extracts.

QUICK FACTS

Cultivated widely in India and tropical Asia. Rasa: tikta, kau; Guna: ruka, laghu; Vīrya: ua; Vipāka: kau. Dosha: traditionally Kapha-Pitta maka in appropriate use; excess may aggravate Pitta. Karma: kuhaghna, kandughna, viaghna and varya in classical descriptions.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Charaka and Suruta discuss Haridrā in multiple therapeutic contexts; Bhvapraka Nighaṇṭu: Hartakydi varga. API includes Haridrā monographs.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Curcuminoids (curcumin, demethoxycurcumin, bisdemethoxycurcumin) and volatile oils such as turmerones.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNAT)

Traditionally used in skin care, wound-care preparations, digestive complaints and inflammatory conditions; also widely used as food.

WHY USE IT? / MAIN BENEFITS

Curcumin has been studied for inflammation and knee osteoarthritis symptoms, but product quality and absorption vary substantially.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Human studies and meta-analyses are promising for some osteoarthritis outcomes but not definitive. Highly bioavailable supplements have been
associated with liver injury in some people.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Food use differs from concentrated supplements. Chra and topical forms are traditional; no single therapeutic dose is appropriate across powders, extracts and enhanced-bioavailability products. Follow the product monograph and practitioner advice.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Haridrā khaa, Nimalak (formulae vary), and numerous topical lepas/tailas.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS

Concentrated supplements may cause reflux, nausea, diarrhoea or constipation; enhanced-bioavailability products have liver-injury reports. Avoid
medicinal-dose supplements during pregnancy unless medically advised. Caution with anticoagulants/antiplatelets and gallbladder or bile-duct
disease.

Sources: API Haridrā monograph; Bhvapraka Nighaṇṭu; NCCIH, “Turmeric: Usefulness and Safety” (accessed 2026).

Tulasī | Holy basil

English: Holy basil Hindi: Tulsi Gujarati: Tulsi Botanical: Ocimum tenuiflorum L. (syn. O. sanctum L.) Family: Lamiaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE

Tulasī is an aromatic herb revered in Indian traditions and used as a medicinal dravya, especially in respiratory and digestive contexts. The name

Tulasī is established; a definitive literal etymology is not asserted. Paryya lists include Suras and Grmya. Scope includes leaves and aerial

parts of O. tenuiflorum; Rama and Krishna tulsi are commonly described cultivated forms, while sweet basil (O. basilicum) is a different species.

Used as fresh svarasa, leaf powder, infusion/decoction and extracts.

QUICK FACTS

Widely cultivated around homes and farms across South Asia. Rasa: kau, tikta; Guna: laghu, ruka; Vīrya: ua; Vipāka: kau (classical descriptions may vary). Dosha: traditionally Kapha-Vāta maka; use thoughtfully in Pitta-prone states. Karma: ksahara, vsahara and dpana-pcana in traditional accounts.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Charaka Saṃhitā references should be tied to a specific edition and context; Bhvapraka Nighaṇṭu and Dhanvantari Nighaṇṭu list Tulasī/Suras. Do not infer a specific indication from a synonym alone.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Eugenol, rosmarinic acid, ursolic acid and volatile oils; concentrations vary by cultivar, plant part and processing.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNAT)

Traditionally used for cough, mild respiratory discomfort, digestive complaints and as a household herbal infusion.

WHY USE IT? / MAIN BENEFITS

A warm infusion may soothe the throat; laboratory antimicrobial or anti-inflammatory findings do not establish treatment efficacy in people.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Human evidence is limited and varies by preparation. Most claims remain traditional or preclinical; it should not replace care for breathing difficulty,

persistent fever or infection.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Fresh leaf, infusion and powder are used traditionally; dose varies by preparation. API status and dosage should be verified for the exact plant part

and formulation; no universal dose is stated here.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Tulasī svarasa and Tulasī-based cough preparations; commercial combinations differ and should be checked ingredient by ingredient.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS

Food-level use is generally different from concentrated extracts. Safety in pregnancy and lactation at medicinal doses is not well established.

Potential glucose-lowering effects and possible interaction with anticoagulants have been discussed; seek clinician advice when taking regular

medicines.

Sources: Bhvapraka Nighaṇṭu; Dhanvantari Nighaṇṭu; pharmacognosy and clinical reviews of Ocimum tenuiflorum.

malak | Indian gooseberry

English: Indian gooseberry / Amla Hindi: Amla Gujarati: Amla Botanical: Phyllanthus emblica L. (syn. Emblica officinalis Gaertn.) Family:

Phyllanthaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE

malak is a deciduous tree whose fruit is used as food and a major Ayurvedic dravya, especially in rasyana traditions. malak is the standard

Sanskrit name; the name is associated with the fruit in classical materia medica. Paryya include Dhtr and Vayasth in traditional lexicons.

Scope: fruit pulp/pericarp; seed and other parts are distinct materials. Forms include fresh fruit, dried fruit powder, juice and compound preparations.

QUICK FACTS

Native to tropical/subtropical Asia and widely cultivated in India. Rasa: five tastes are described except lavaa, with mla prominent; Guna: laghu,

ruka; Vīrya: ta; Vipāka: madhura. Dosha: traditionally tridoa-balancing, especially Pitta-maka. Karma: rasyana, cakuya and dpana

in classical descriptions.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Charaka: malak appears in rasyana contexts including the Cyavanapra tradition. Bhvapraka Nighaṇṭu: Hartakydi varga; API

includes malak fruit monographs.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Hydrolysable tannins (including emblicanin-related compounds reported in extracts), gallic acid, ellagic acid, flavonoids and vitamin C; measured

vitamin C varies with processing and assay.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNAT)

Traditionally used in rasyana preparations, digestive support and bowel-regulating combinations; fruit is also eaten as food.

WHY USE IT? / MAIN BENEFITS

Provides polyphenols and is a useful food fruit. Clinical claims for metabolic or cardiovascular outcomes remain product- and study-dependent.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Small clinical trials report possible changes in selected lipid or glycaemic measures, but larger, better-controlled studies are needed; it is not a

replacement for prescribed treatment.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Fresh fruit, juice and dried fruit powder are used. Dose depends on form and indication; API monographs standardize identity/quality rather than

provide one dose for every preparation. Follow the specific formulation label and practitioner advice.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Triphala, Cyavanapra and malak rasyana preparations (formulae vary by text).

SAFETY & CAUTIONS

Food use is generally well tolerated. Concentrated products may cause gastrointestinal symptoms and could add to glucose-lowering or antiplatelet

effects; check with a clinician if taking anticoagulants, diabetes medicines or preparing for surgery. Pregnancy/lactation supplement safety is

insufficiently established.

Sources: API malak monograph; Charaka Saṃhitā (rasyana context); Bhvapraka Nighaṇṭu; clinical reviews.

Brhm | Brahmi (identity-sensitive name)

English: Brahmi □ Hindi: Brahmi □ Gujarati: Brahmi □ Botanical: Bacopa monnieri (L.) Wettst. is often sold as Brahmi □ Family: Plantaginaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE

Brhm is a name used for medhya herbs in Ayurveda, but common-name usage is ambiguous: Bacopa monnieri is widely marketed as Brahmi,
while Centella asiatica is also called Brahmi in some regions and is separately identified as Makapar in many API records. Do not treat these species as interchangeable. Classical paryya and exact etymology depend on the text and identity. Scope here is Bacopa monnieri aerial
parts; confirm the botanical identity on raw material and products.

QUICK FACTS

Bacopa monnieri grows in wet, marshy habitats across tropical/subtropical regions. Rasa/Guna/Vīrya/Vipāka: classical attributes vary by source;
data not asserted without a verified species-specific nighau citation. Dosha and karma descriptions also vary with identity. Commonly described
traditionally as medhya, but that term does not establish clinical efficacy.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

API has a Makapar (Centella asiatica) monograph; this is not evidence that it is the same species as Bacopa monnieri. Verify Brhm entries against the exact Bhvapraka/Dhanvantari edition used.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Bacosides (including bacoside A-related saponins) are studied in Bacopa monnieri; composition varies by extract and plant material.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNAT)

Traditionally used in medhya formulations for memory and cognition; species identity must be confirmed before applying a traditional indication.

WHY USE IT? / MAIN BENEFITS

Some standardized Bacopa extracts have been studied for selected memory outcomes after repeated use; effects are not immediate and evidence is
not uniform.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Randomized trials and reviews suggest possible modest effects on some memory measures, with gastrointestinal adverse effects common. Results
cannot be generalized to all products labelled Brahmi.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Do not transfer a dose between Bacopa and Centella. Use only a botanically authenticated product and follow the specific pharmacopoeial/formulation monograph or clinician's instructions; a universal dose is not stated.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Brahmi ghta and Brahmi-based medhya preparations exist in multiple formulae; verify the ingredient species and text-specific recipe.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS

May cause nausea, abdominal cramps, diarrhoea or fatigue. Potential interactions with medicines affecting cholinergic activity or thyroid function are
possible; evidence is limited. Pregnancy/lactation safety for concentrated extracts is insufficiently established.

Sources: PCIM&H;/API Makapar monograph (Centella asiatica); peer-reviewed Bacopa monnieri clinical reviews; classical nighau editions should be cited by
edition.

Makapar | Gotu kola

English: Gotu kola / Indian pennywort Hindi: Mandukparni Gujarati: Mandukparni Botanical: Centella asiatica (L.) Urb. Family: Apiaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE

Makapar is a creeping herb of moist habitats; the whole plant is used as a classical dravya, often discussed in medhya contexts. The name
refers to a leaf shape traditionally compared with a frog (maka), though wording can vary across sources. Paryya include Mak and Bheki in some lexicons. Scope: authenticated Centella asiatica whole plant; distinguish it from Bacopa monnieri, which is also sold as Brahmi. Used
as svarasa, powder, decoction and extracts.

QUICK FACTS

Occurs in damp places across tropical Asia, including India. Classical Rasa/Guna/Vīrya/Vipāka descriptions vary by nighau; where not verified
for a specific edition, data should be checked rather than assumed. Karma often described as medhya and vraaropaa in traditional literature.
Dosha action is preparation- and source-dependent.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

PCIM&H;/API: Makapar (Centella asiatica) whole-plant monograph, Part I, Vol. VIII (2011). Classical references should distinguish Makapar from Brhm/Bacopa.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Triterpenoid saponins such as asiaticoside and madecassoside, plus asiatic and madecassic acids; levels vary by plant and extract.
TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNAT)
Traditionally used in wound-care preparations and medhya formulations; also used in topical products. These uses are not interchangeable with
evidence for oral treatment.

WHY USE IT? / MAIN BENEFITS

Topical Centella extracts are studied for skin repair and scarring; oral cognition claims remain uncertain.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Clinical evidence is limited and formulation-specific; many wound-healing and neuroprotective claims remain preclinical. Avoid assuming that all gotu
kola products have equivalent effects.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Whole-plant powder, juice and extracts are described, but no single dose is suitable for all products. Follow the authenticated monograph/product
specification and qualified practitioner advice.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Makapar-based medhya formulations and topical preparations; named formulations vary by text and manufacturer.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS

Possible nausea, headache, drowsiness or allergic skin reactions; rare liver-injury reports have been associated with oral use. Avoid unsupervised
concentrated use in liver disease and consult a clinician during pregnancy/lactation or when taking sedatives.
Sources: PCIM&H;/API Makapar monograph; peer-reviewed Centella asiatica reviews; Bhvapraka/Dhanvantari Nighaṇṭu editions for classical attributes.

Guḍūcī | Guduchi

English: Heart-leaved moonseed • Hindi: Giloy • Gujarati: Galo • Botanical: Tinospora cordifolia (Willd.) Hook. f. & Thomson • Family: Menispermaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Guḍūcī is a climbing shrub whose mature stem is a principal Ayurvedic drug, traditionally valued as a rasāyana and for jvara-related uses. The name is established in classical materia medica; a definitive literal etymology is not asserted here. Paryāya in lexicons include Amṛtā and Chinnodbhavā (lists vary by text). Scope: authenticated T. cordifolia stem; do not confuse it with Tinospora crispa or other Tinospora species. Forms include stem powder, decoction, fresh juice and compound preparations.

QUICK FACTS
Habitat: tropical Indian subcontinent; commonly cultivated and climbing on trees. Rasa: tikta, kaṣāya; Guna: guru, snigdha (commonly described); Vīrya: uṣṇa; Vipāka: madhura. Dosha: traditionally tridoṣa-supportive, especially Pitta-Kapha in selected contexts; source descriptions vary. Karma: jvaraghna, dīpana, rasāyana in classical accounts.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES
Charaka Saṃhitā discusses Guḍūcī in therapeutic and rasāyana contexts; Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu and Dhanvantari Nighaṇṭu include Guḍūcī/Amṛtā entries. Cite exact chapter and verse only after checking the chosen edition.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS
Diterpenoid lactones, including tinosporaside-related compounds; alkaloids, glycosides and polysaccharides have also been reported. Composition varies by plant part and extract.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)
Traditionally used in fever-related formulations, digestive support and rasāyana combinations. Traditional use does not establish effectiveness for any particular infection or chronic disease.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS
May be used within a practitioner-guided traditional regimen; it should not replace evaluation of persistent fever or suspected infection.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE
Human evidence is limited and formulation-specific. Published case reports have linked Tinospora cordifolia products with liver injury, including autoimmune-like hepatitis; benefit-risk assessment is important.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE
Stem powder, decoction and juice are traditional forms. A single dose is not stated: dose depends on preparation, identity and clinical context. Confirm any dose in the applicable API/AFI entry and with a qualified practitioner.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS
Guḍūcyādi kvātha and other Guḍūcī-containing preparations; recipes and ingredient proportions vary by text.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
Avoid unsupervised use, especially with liver disease or autoimmune disorders. Liver injury has been reported; stop and seek medical advice for jaundice, dark urine or severe fatigue. Pregnancy/lactation safety is insufficiently established. Possible interactions with immunosuppressants and glucose-lowering medicines require clinician review.

Sources: API/PCIM&H; monographs where applicable; Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu; peer-reviewed reports and reviews of Tinospora-associated liver injury.

Śatāvarī | Shatavari

English: Wild asparagus • Hindi: Shatavari • Gujarati: Shatavari • Botanical: Asparagus racemosus Willd. • Family: Asparagaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Śatāvarī is a climbing or scrambling perennial with tuberous roots used as the main Ayurvedic drug. It is traditionally described as a nourishing, reproductive-health and rasāyana dravya. The name is often interpreted traditionally as “having a hundred [roots/spouses],” but the precise etymology should be treated cautiously. Paryāya include Nārāyaṇī and Bahusūtā in some lexicons. Scope: authenticated roots; do not substitute unrelated Asparagus species. Used as root powder, decoction, ghee-based preparations and extracts.

QUICK FACTS
Found across parts of India and tropical Asia, often in dry deciduous forests. Rasa: madhura, tikta; Guna: guru, snigdha; Vīrya: śīta; Vipāka: madhura (common classical descriptions). Dosha: traditionally Vāta-Pitta śāmaka. Karma: bṛṃhaṇa, stanyajanana and rasāyana in classical accounts.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu includes Śatāvarī; classical Saṃhitā references vary by therapeutic context. Verify exact text location against the edition cited.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Steroidal saponins (shatavarins), saponin glycosides and polysaccharides have been reported; composition varies by root and extract.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Traditionally used in nourishing and reproductive-health formulations, including selected lactation-related and urinary contexts. These are traditional indications, not guarantees of benefit.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

It is used as a restorative herb in Ayurveda; clinical evidence for lactation, menopause or fertility outcomes remains limited.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Small clinical studies exist, but evidence is not sufficient to establish efficacy across conditions or products. Hormonal activity and long-term safety need further study.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Root powder and compound preparations are traditional. No universal dose is given because root powders, extracts and ghṛta formulations differ; follow the applicable monograph and practitioner advice.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Śatāvarī cūrṇa, Śatāvarī ghṛta and other compound formulations; exact compositions vary.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
Avoid self-prescribing during pregnancy or for hormone-sensitive conditions. Possible gastrointestinal effects and allergic reactions. Lactation safety claims should not replace assessment of feeding difficulties. Check with a clinician if taking diuretics, glucose-lowering medicines or hormone-related treatment.

Sources: Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu; API/PCIM&H; monographs where applicable; peer-reviewed reviews of Asparagus racemosus.

Ārdraka | Ginger

English: Fresh ginger • Hindi: Adrak • Gujarati: Adu • Botanical: Zingiber officinale Roscoe • Family: Zingiberaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Ārdraka is the fresh rhizome of ginger, used as a food and Ayurvedic dravya; Śuṇṭhī refers to the dried rhizome and is not identical in processing or properties. The Sanskrit name refers to the fresh form in classical usage. Nighaṇṭu synonyms differ by source. Scope: fresh rhizome for Ārdraka and dried rhizome for Śuṇṭhī; avoid confusing either with unrelated ginger-family species. Forms include fresh juice, paste, infusion, powder and cooked food.

QUICK FACTS
Cultivated widely in tropical and subtropical regions. Rasa: kaṭu; Guna: laghu, snigdha (descriptions vary); Vīrya: uṣṇa; Vipāka: madhura is often given for Śuṇṭhī, while fresh ginger descriptions can differ. Dosha: traditionally Kapha-Vāta śāmaka; excessive use may aggravate Pitta. Karma: dīpana, pācana, āmapācana.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Charaka and Suśruta discuss Ārdraka/Śuṇṭhī in multiple contexts; Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu lists ginger forms. Check the exact entry for fresh versus dried rhizome.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Gingerols (notably 6-gingerol in fresh rhizome), shogaols (increased with drying/heating), zingerone and volatile oils.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Traditionally used for indigestion, nausea, appetite support and respiratory formulations; also a common culinary ingredient.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

Ginger may help some types of nausea and can be useful as a food spice. Effects depend on dose and condition.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Clinical evidence is strongest for some nausea settings, including pregnancy-related nausea, but study quality and preparations vary. It is not a substitute for evaluation of severe or persistent vomiting.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Food use differs from medicinal supplements. Fresh juice, paste and dried powder are used traditionally; no single dose applies to all forms. Use clinician guidance during pregnancy or when taking medicines that affect clotting.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Trikaṭu (with Śuṇṭhī, Marica and Pippalī), Ārdraka svarasa and numerous digestive formulations.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
May cause heartburn, abdominal discomfort or mouth irritation. Concentrated products warrant caution with anticoagulants/antiplatelets and before surgery. Pregnancy use should be discussed with a healthcare professional, especially at supplement doses.

Sources: Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu; API ginger monograph where applicable; systematic reviews of ginger for nausea.

Harītakī | Haritaki

English: Chebulic myrobalan • Hindi: Harad • Gujarati: Harade • Botanical: Terminalia chebula Retz. • Family: Combretaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Harītakī is a deciduous tree whose dried fruit is a major Ayurvedic dravya, especially in digestive and rasāyana traditions. The name is well established; popular derivations linking it with Hari are traditional explanations rather than certain linguistic proof. Paryāya include Abhayā and Pathyā. Scope: authenticated fruit pericarp; fruit maturity and processing affect the drug. Used as fruit powder and in decoctions and compound formulations.

QUICK FACTS
Native to South and Southeast Asia; widely used in India. Rasa: five tastes except lavaṇa are described, with kaṣāya prominent; Guna: laghu, rukṣa; Vīrya: uṣṇa; Vipāka: madhura (common classical description). Dosha: traditionally tridoṣa-balancing, particularly Vāta śāmaka. Karma: anulomana, dīpana and rasāyana.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Charaka includes Harītakī in classical therapeutic contexts; Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu: Harītakyādi varga. Exact chapter references depend on the formulation and edition.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Hydrolysable tannins including chebulagic acid and chebulinic acid, gallic acid, ellagic acid and other polyphenols.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Traditionally used for bowel regulation and digestive support; it is one of the three fruits in Triphalā.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

May support bowel regularity for some people, but effects depend on preparation and individual response.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Much evidence is preclinical; robust clinical evidence for specific disease treatment is limited. Do not assume laboratory antioxidant effects equal clinical benefit.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Fruit powder and decoction are traditional. Dose depends on processing and formulation; use the applicable pharmacopoeial/formulary reference and practitioner advice rather than a universal number.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Triphalā cūrṇa and other Harītakī-containing preparations; recipes vary.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
May cause loose stools, cramps or dehydration if laxative effects are excessive. Avoid self-treatment for persistent bowel changes, severe abdominal pain or suspected obstruction. Pregnancy/lactation safety at medicinal doses is not well established. Check interactions if taking regular medicines.

Sources: API Harītakī monograph; Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu; reviews of Terminalia chebula.

Bibhītaka | Bibhitaki

English: Beleric myrobalan • Hindi: Baheda • Gujarati: Baheda • Botanical: Terminalia bellirica (Gaertn.) Roxb. • Family: Combretaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Bibhītaka is a large deciduous tree whose dried fruit is used in Ayurvedic materia medica and as one of the three Triphalā fruits. The Sanskrit name and its traditional associations appear in nighaṇṭu literature; a definitive literal etymology is not asserted. Paryāya include Akṣa and Kalidruma in some lists. Scope: authenticated fruit pericarp; distinguish it from Harītakī and Āmalakī. Used as powder, decoction and compound formulations.

QUICK FACTS
Native to the Indian subcontinent and parts of Southeast Asia. Rasa: kaṣāya prominent; Guna: rukṣa, laghu (common descriptions); Vīrya: uṣṇa is commonly given; Vipāka: madhura. Dosha: traditionally Kapha-Pitta śāmaka. Karma: kaṣāya, kapha-related and bowel-supportive actions in classical descriptions; details vary by source.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu: Harītakyādi varga; Bibhītaka appears in Triphalā traditions and classical formulations. Confirm specific Saṃhitā citations against the chosen edition.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Tannins and polyphenols, including gallic acid and ellagic acid-related compounds; composition depends on fruit and extraction.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Traditionally used in respiratory and digestive formulations and as part of Triphalā; classical indications vary by text.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

Its principal familiar role is as one component of Triphalā. Evidence for isolated Bibhītaka as a treatment is limited.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Predominantly preclinical studies; high-quality human clinical evidence for specific conditions is insufficient.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Fruit powder/decoction and compound formulations are traditional. No single dose is provided for all products; follow the relevant formulation specification and practitioner advice.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Triphalā cūrṇa and other compound preparations containing Bibhītaka.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
May cause gastrointestinal upset. Use caution with laxative combinations and regular medicines because interaction data are limited. Medicinal-dose safety in pregnancy/lactation is insufficiently established.

Sources: Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu; API/PCIM&H; monographs where applicable; peer-reviewed Terminalia bellirica reviews.

Arjuna | Arjuna

English: Arjuna tree • Hindi: Arjun • Gujarati: Arjun • Botanical: Terminalia arjuna (Roxb. ex DC.) Wight & Arn. • Family: Combretaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Arjuna is a large tree whose bark is the principal Ayurvedic drug, especially known in traditional texts for heart-related support. The name is established in Sanskrit; a certain etymology is not asserted. Nighaṇṭu synonyms include Kakubha and Nadīsāra in some sources. Scope: authenticated stem bark; leaf, fruit and bark extracts are not interchangeable. Common forms include bark powder, decoction and standardized extracts.

QUICK FACTS
Common along riverbanks and in parts of the Indian subcontinent. Rasa: kaṣāya; Guna: rukṣa, laghu (common descriptions); Vīrya: śīta; Vipāka: kaṭu is reported in some sources; verify against the selected nighaṇṭu. Dosha: traditionally Kapha-Pitta śāmaka. Karma: hṛdya in classical accounts.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu and other materia medica sources include Arjuna/Kakubha. Specific heart indications should be cited to a verified classical passage, not inferred from the common epithet alone.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Triterpenoids, flavonoids, tannins and phytosterols; extract profiles vary with bark source and processing.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Traditionally used in formulations for cardiac support and selected bleeding or wound-related contexts depending on the source.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

Arjuna bark has been studied as an adjunct in some cardiovascular settings, but it must not replace prescribed heart medicines.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Small clinical studies suggest possible effects on selected cardiac symptoms or measures, but evidence remains limited and heterogeneous; larger trials are needed.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Bark powder, decoction and extracts differ substantially. No universal dose is stated; use only with clinician oversight, especially in cardiovascular disease.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Arjunāriṣṭa and Arjuna bark preparations; ingredient lists and fermentation methods vary by formulation.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
May affect blood pressure or blood glucose and could interact with cardiac, antihypertensive or antidiabetic medicines. Avoid self-treatment for chest pain, breathlessness or fainting; seek urgent care. Pregnancy/lactation safety is not established.

Sources: Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu; pharmacognosy reviews of Terminalia arjuna; clinical reviews of Arjuna bark in cardiovascular conditions.

Yaṣṭimadhu | Licorice

English: Licorice / liquorice • Hindi: Mulethi • Gujarati: Jethimadh • Botanical: Glycyrrhiza glabra L. • Family: Fabaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Yaṣṭimadhu is a perennial herb whose roots and stolons are used as a sweet-tasting Ayurvedic drug. The name is established; traditional glosses connect it with sweetness. Paryāya include Madhuka and Klītaka in some lexicons, but synonym lists vary. Scope: authenticated root/stolon of G. glabra; other Glycyrrhiza species and deglycyrrhizinated products differ chemically. Forms include powder, decoction, lozenges and extracts.

QUICK FACTS
Native to parts of Europe and Asia; cultivated in temperate and subtropical regions. Rasa: madhura; Guna: guru, snigdha; Vīrya: śīta; Vipāka: madhura. Dosha: traditionally Vāta-Pitta śāmaka; excess may aggravate Kapha. Karma: kaṇṭhya, vraṇaropaṇa and śothahara in traditional descriptions.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu includes Yaṣṭimadhu/Madhuka entries; Charaka and other Saṃhitās use it in multiple formulations. Exact textual references vary by context.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Glycyrrhizin (glycyrrhizic acid), liquiritin, isoliquiritigenin and other flavonoids.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Traditionally used for throat and cough preparations, gastric comfort and as a sweetening/vehicle ingredient in formulations.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

May soothe throat irritation in some preparations. It is not a proven treatment for ulcers, infection or chronic respiratory disease.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Some clinical evidence exists for selected topical or procedural uses, but many oral indications have limited evidence. Glycyrrhizin-related toxicity is well documented.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Root powder and extracts are traditional; product glycyrrhizin content varies greatly. No universal dose is safe for everyone; avoid prolonged unsupervised use.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Yaṣṭimadhu cūrṇa and numerous throat, gastric and compound formulations.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
Can cause hypertension, low potassium, fluid retention and abnormal heart rhythms, especially with prolonged/high exposure. Avoid in pregnancy and in people with hypertension, heart/kidney disease or low potassium unless medically directed. Interacts with diuretics, digoxin, corticosteroids and antihypertensives.

Sources: Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu; NCCIH licorice safety information; systematic reviews of Glycyrrhiza glabra.

Guggulu | Guggul

English: Indian bdellium resin • Hindi: Guggul • Gujarati: Gugal • Botanical source: Commiphora wightii (Arn.) Bhandari (syn. C. mukul) • Family: Burseraceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Guggulu is the oleo-gum-resin exudate of Commiphora wightii, used as a medicinal raw material and in numerous compound Ayurvedic formulations. The name Guggulu is established in classical literature; detailed etymology is not asserted here. Paryāya lists include Devadhūpa and Kauśika in some sources. Scope: authenticated purified resin; raw resin and śodhita Guggulu are not equivalent. Forms include resin mass, powder and processed tablets, usually within compound formulations.

QUICK FACTS
Native to arid and semi-arid regions of India and nearby areas; wild populations are threatened by overharvesting. Classical Rasa: tikta, kaṭu, kaṣāya are reported; Guna: laghu, rukṣa, sūkṣma; Vīrya: uṣṇa; Vipāka: kaṭu. Dosha: traditionally Vāta-Kapha śāmaka. Karma: lekhana, śothahara and medohara in selected formulations.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu and classical formulation texts describe Guggulu; many named guggulu formulations have separate recipes. Check the exact source for each compound medicine.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Guggulsterones (E and Z), resin acids, volatile constituents and other terpenoids; levels vary by source and processing.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Traditionally used in compound preparations for joint complaints and selected metabolic or inflammatory indications; effect depends on the full formula.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

Its role is usually as one ingredient in a formulated medicine, not as a self-prescribed standalone resin.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Clinical studies of guggul extracts for lipids have been inconsistent; some showed no benefit and possible LDL increases. Evidence for many traditional indications is limited.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Purified Guggulu is generally used in compound formulations. Do not apply a universal resin dose; shodhana method, formula, extract and patient factors matter.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Yogarāja Guggulu, Kaiśora Guggulu and other named formulations, each with distinct ingredients and indications.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
May cause rash, gastrointestinal upset and possible liver-related adverse effects; potential interactions with anticoagulants, thyroid medicines and other drugs are possible. Avoid unsupervised use during pregnancy/lactation or in liver disease. Use only authenticated, properly processed material.

Sources: Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu; AFI for individual formulations where listed; peer-reviewed clinical reviews of Commiphora wightii.

Pippalī | Long pepper

English: Indian long pepper • Hindi: Pippali • Gujarati: Pipali • Botanical: Piper longum L. • Family: Piperaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Pippalī is a climbing plant whose dried fruit is a classical Ayurvedic drug, with root also used in certain traditions and preparations. The name is established in Sanskrit materia medica. Paryāya include Kaṇā and Magadhī in some lexicons. Scope: distinguish fruit from Pippalīmūla (root) and from black pepper (Piper nigrum). Forms include powder, decoction and compound formulations.

QUICK FACTS
Native to the Indian subcontinent and parts of Southeast Asia, growing in warm humid habitats. Rasa: kaṭu; Guna: laghu, snigdha, tīkṣṇa; Vīrya: anūṣṇa/ uṣṇa descriptions vary; Vipāka: madhura. Dosha: traditionally Vāta-Kapha śāmaka; use carefully in Pitta-prone conditions. Karma: dīpana, pācana, śvāsahara in traditional descriptions.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Charaka Saṃhitā and Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu discuss Pippalī in formulations; Pippalīmūla is a distinct material and should not be conflated with fruit.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Piperine and related alkaloids, piperlongumine and volatile oils; concentration differs by plant part.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Traditionally used in respiratory and digestive formulations and in Trikaṭu with Śuṇṭhī and Marica.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

It is a warming spice used in traditional digestive and respiratory preparations; it is not a substitute for treatment of asthma or infection.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Most evidence is preclinical. Piperine can alter absorption/metabolism of some drugs, making interactions clinically relevant.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Fruit powder and compound formulations are traditional. No universal dose is stated; piperine-containing products may change drug exposure. Follow a qualified practitioner's advice.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Trikaṭu cūrṇa, Pippalī cūrṇa and numerous compound preparations.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
May cause burning, reflux or irritation. Potential interactions with medicines metabolized by drug enzymes/transporters; consult a pharmacist or clinician if taking regular medication. Pregnancy/lactation safety at medicinal doses is insufficiently established.

Sources: Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu; API/PCIM&H; monographs where applicable; reviews of Piper longum and piperine drug interactions.

Marica | Black pepper

English: Black pepper • Hindi: Kali mirch • Gujarati: Mari • Botanical: Piper nigrum L. • Family: Piperaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Marica is a perennial climbing vine whose dried unripe fruit is the black pepper spice and Ayurvedic drug. The Sanskrit name is established in classical materia medica; a precise etymology is not asserted. Paryāya include Uṣaṇa and Dharmapattana in some lexicons. Scope: dried fruit of P. nigrum; white pepper is processed fruit and long pepper is a different species, P. longum. Forms include powder, decoction and compound preparations.

QUICK FACTS
Native to the Western Ghats region and cultivated across tropical regions. Rasa: kaṭu; Guna: laghu, tīkṣṇa, rukṣa; Vīrya: uṣṇa; Vipāka: kaṭu. Dosha: traditionally Kapha-Vāta śāmaka; may aggravate Pitta. Karma: dīpana, pācana and krimighna in classical descriptions.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu includes Marica; it is a component of Trikaṭu. Verify text-specific synonyms against the edition used.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Piperine is the major pungent alkaloid; volatile oils include compounds such as β-caryophyllene and limonene.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Traditionally used as a digestive spice and in respiratory and digestive compound formulations; also common in food.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

Food-level use adds flavour and may stimulate digestive secretions. Concentrated piperine is pharmacologically active and can affect drug exposure.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Laboratory evidence supports bioactivity, but clinical evidence for black pepper as a treatment is limited. Piperine can increase absorption of certain compounds and medicines.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Culinary use is distinct from medicinal powder or concentrated piperine. No universal medicinal dose is stated; use practitioner guidance for therapeutic preparations.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Trikaṭu cūrṇa and many compound formulas containing Marica.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
May worsen reflux or gastrointestinal irritation. Piperine may interact with anticoagulants and medicines metabolized by CYP enzymes or transporters; obtain professional advice before using concentrated supplements. Pregnancy/lactation supplement safety is not established.

Sources: Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu; pharmacognosy reviews of Piper nigrum; peer-reviewed reviews of piperine drug interactions.

Maṇḍūra / Maṇḍūka? — Verify before use

Common-name note: “Brahmi” can refer to different plants; this page covers Brahmi identity caution • Botanical candidates: Bacopa monnieri or Centella asiatica • Families: Plantaginaceae / Apiaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
The common name “Brahmi” is ambiguous in commerce and regional usage. Bacopa monnieri is widely sold as Brahmi, while Centella asiatica is commonly called Maṇḍūkaparṇī and is also labelled Brahmi in some markets. These are distinct species with different constituents and monographs. This entry is an identity-control page, not a claim that the plants are interchangeable. Confirm the Latin binomial, plant part and voucher/authentication details before applying classical properties or dosage.

QUICK FACTS
Identity is the first safety and quality step. Bacopa: wet habitats; studied bacosides. Centella: moist tropical habitats; studied asiaticoside/madecassoside. Do not transfer rasa-pañcaka, dose or evidence from one species to the other. Classical synonyms are text- and identity-dependent; where not securely verified, data not established.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

API/PCIM&H; has a Maṇḍūkaparṇī monograph for Centella asiatica. Brāhmī entries and identifications should be checked against a named Bhāvaprakāśa/Dhanvantari Nighaṇṭu edition and a reliable botanical reference.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Bacopa monnieri: bacosides and related saponins. Centella asiatica: asiaticoside, madecassoside, asiatic acid and madecassic acid. The profiles are not interchangeable.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Traditional medhya claims are associated with Brahmi-labelled materials, but exact application must follow authenticated species and source text. Centella also has topical uses in skin preparations.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

Correct identification prevents applying the wrong traditional monograph, dose or safety advice to a product with a shared vernacular name.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Bacopa has limited-to-moderate clinical research for selected memory outcomes with specific standardized extracts. Centella clinical evidence is also formulation-specific and limited. Evidence for one species cannot be used to validate the other.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

No dose supplied for an unidentified “Brahmi” product. First authenticate the species and plant part, then consult the relevant monograph and qualified practitioner.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Products may be powders, capsules, ghṛta or other compound preparations; check the full label and botanical identity.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
Do not use an unidentified product medicinally. Bacopa may cause gastrointestinal effects; Centella has possible sedation and rare liver-injury reports. Pregnancy/lactation safety for concentrated products is insufficiently established.

Sources: PCIM&H;/API Maṇḍūkaparṇī monograph; peer-reviewed reviews of Bacopa monnieri and Centella asiatica.

Śuṇṭhī | Dried ginger

English: Dried ginger • Hindi: Sonth • Gujarati: Sunth • Botanical: Zingiber officinale Roscoe • Family: Zingiberaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Śuṇṭhī is the dried rhizome of ginger and is treated as a distinct drug form from fresh Ārdraka in Ayurvedic practice. Drying changes the relative amounts of gingerols and shogaols. The name is established in classical materia medica. Scope: properly identified, dried Zingiber officinale rhizome; do not confuse with other Zingiberaceae. Common forms include powder, decoction and compound formulations.

QUICK FACTS
Cultivated throughout tropical/subtropical regions. Rasa: kaṭu; Guna: laghu, snigdha (common descriptions); Vīrya: uṣṇa; Vipāka: madhura is commonly reported. Dosha: traditionally Kapha-Vāta śāmaka; excessive use may aggravate Pitta. Karma: dīpana, pācana and āmapācana.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu describes Śuṇṭhī and Ārdraka as related but distinct forms. Classical formulation texts include Śuṇṭhī in Trikaṭu and many digestive preparations.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Shogaols, gingerols, zingerone and volatile oils; relative concentrations vary with drying and storage.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Traditionally used for digestive sluggishness, nausea and as an ingredient in respiratory and digestive formulations.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

May help some nausea symptoms; culinary use and medicinal-dose supplementation should be distinguished.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Clinical research supports possible benefit for some nausea settings, but evidence varies by population and product. Evidence for many other claims remains limited.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Powder and decoction are traditional forms; no universal dose applies to all products or indications. Confirm the applicable API/AFI monograph and clinician advice.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Trikaṭu cūrṇa, digestive powders and numerous compound formulations.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
May worsen reflux or cause gastrointestinal irritation. Caution with anticoagulant/antiplatelet medicines and before surgery when using concentrated supplements. Pregnancy-related use should be discussed with a clinician.

Sources: Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu; API/AFI entries where applicable; systematic reviews of ginger.

Karīra? — Cumin identity check

Entry note: This batch does not assign “cumin” to a Sanskrit synonym without checking the exact botanical • Common cumin: Cuminum cyminum L. • Family: Apiaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Cumin is an annual aromatic herb whose dried fruits are used as a culinary spice and in traditional digestive preparations. In Ayurvedic sources, Jeeraka generally refers to cumin, but species, regional names and black cumin terminology can be confused. This entry covers Cuminum cyminum L. only; Nigella sativa (black seed/black cumin in commerce) is a different species in Ranunculaceae. The Sanskrit synonym list and etymology should be checked against a specified nighaṇṭu edition rather than inferred from modern common names.

QUICK FACTS
Cultivated in India and other warm regions. Classical rasa-pañcaka should be taken from a verified Jeeraka entry for the specific material; not asserted here where edition-specific details have not been checked. Culinary use is widespread; medicinal preparations include powder, infusion and compound digestive formulations.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Check Jeeraka in the selected Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu/Dhanvantari Nighaṇṭu edition and the relevant API entry before assigning exact Sanskrit properties or a chapter citation.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Cuminaldehyde, terpenes such as γ-terpinene and p-cymene, and other volatile-oil constituents.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Traditional culinary and digestive use; used in food and selected compound formulations.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

Cumin adds flavour and is used traditionally for digestive comfort, but food use does not establish treatment of disease.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Most pharmacological evidence is preclinical; clinical evidence for specific therapeutic claims is limited.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Food seasoning differs from medicinal powder or concentrated extract. No universal dose stated; verify the specific pharmacopoeial/formulary entry.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Jeeraka-based powders and digestive formulations; exact formulas vary by source.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
Culinary amounts are generally different from concentrated supplements. Allergy and gastrointestinal upset are possible; medicinal-dose safety during pregnancy/lactation and interactions are not sufficiently established.

Sources: API/PCIM&H; materials where available; botanical references for Cuminum cyminum; named nighaṇṭu edition needed for classical attributes.

Dhānyaka | Coriander

English: Coriander • Hindi: Dhaniya • Gujarati: Dhana • Botanical: Coriandrum sativum L. • Family: Apiaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Dhānyaka is an annual aromatic herb whose dried fruits (commonly called seeds) and fresh leaves are used as food; the dried fruits are the usual Ayurvedic materia-medica drug. The Sanskrit name is established in classical texts. Paryāya vary by lexicon and should be verified against the chosen edition. Scope: distinguish dried fruits from fresh leaves and from other Apiaceae spices. Forms include powder, infusion/decoction and culinary preparations.

QUICK FACTS
Widely cultivated in India and temperate/subtropical regions. Classical descriptions commonly give kaṣāya/tikta or kaṭu-related taste descriptions depending on the source and plant part; exact rasa-pañcaka should be checked in the chosen nighaṇṭu. Traditionally described as dīpana and pācana; do not infer identical properties for leaves and fruits.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu and other nighaṇṭus contain Dhānyaka entries; check the specific text and plant part before citing precise synonyms or verse numbers.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Linalool is a major volatile-oil constituent of coriander fruits; also contains other terpenes, flavonoids and phenolic compounds.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Used as a culinary spice and traditionally in digestive and cooling preparations depending on the formulation.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

Coriander is a familiar food herb and spice; evidence for treating specific disorders remains limited.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Mostly laboratory and preliminary clinical research; robust evidence for disease treatment is insufficient.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Food use is common. Powder and infusion are traditional, but no universal medicinal dose is asserted without a verified monograph/formula.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Dhānyaka-based digestive preparations and compound powders; recipes vary.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
Food quantities are generally well tolerated; allergy is possible. Concentrated products may have uncertain interactions. Pregnancy/lactation safety at medicinal doses is not well established.

Sources: Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu; botanical/pharmacognosy references for Coriandrum sativum; API entries where applicable.

Jīraka | Cumin

English: Cumin • Hindi: Jeera • Gujarati: Jeeru • Botanical: Cuminum cyminum L. • Family: Apiaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Jīraka is the dried fruit of Cuminum cyminum, widely used as a spice and in Ayurvedic digestive preparations. The Sanskrit name is established; a precise etymology is not asserted here. Classical lists distinguish types of Jīraka in some sources. Scope: common cumin only; Nigella sativa is a different species often sold as black cumin/black seed, and Bunium persicum is another distinct spice. Used as powder, infusion, decoction and compound preparations.

QUICK FACTS
Cultivated in India and other warm, dry regions. Rasa-pañcaka differs somewhat across classical references; verify the chosen nighaṇṭu entry rather than treating one modern profile as universal. Traditionally used as dīpana-pācana and for digestive comfort. Dosha action depends on preparation and quantity.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu includes Jīraka-related entries; exact synonyms and varieties should be checked against the edition. Avoid assigning Nigella sativa properties to Cuminum cyminum.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Cuminaldehyde, γ-terpinene, p-cymene and other volatile-oil constituents.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Traditional digestive and culinary use; appears in compound powders and household preparations.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

Can support flavour and dietary variety; evidence for therapeutic effects beyond food use is preliminary.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Primarily preclinical evidence and small studies; high-quality clinical evidence for specific diseases is insufficient.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Food seasoning differs from medicinal powder/extract. No universal therapeutic dose stated; check the applicable API/AFI source and practitioner advice.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Jīraka-based digestive powders and compound formulations; recipes vary by text.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
Allergy or gastrointestinal irritation is possible. Concentrated products require caution in pregnancy/lactation and with regular medicines because data are limited.

Sources: Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu; botanical references for Cuminum cyminum; API/AFI materials where applicable.

Madhurikā / Miśreyā? — Fennel

English: Fennel • Hindi: Saunf • Gujarati: Variyali • Botanical: Foeniculum vulgare Mill. • Family: Apiaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Fennel is an aromatic flowering plant whose dried fruits are used as a spice and in traditional digestive preparations. Sanskrit synonyms vary by text and regional usage; Madhurikā and Miśreyā are reported in some sources but should be verified in the selected nighaṇṭu. Scope: Foeniculum vulgare fruits; do not confuse with anise or dill. Common forms include whole fruits, powder, infusion and compound preparations.

QUICK FACTS
Cultivated in India and many temperate/subtropical regions. Exact classical rasa-pañcaka and synonyms should be checked against a named edition; traditional descriptions commonly emphasize aromatic, digestive use. Fruit and essential oil are different exposure forms.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Verify the Foeniculum vulgare entry and synonym list in the chosen Bhāvaprakāśa/Dhanvantari Nighaṇṭu edition; do not cite a Sanskrit name without a traceable source.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Anethole, fenchone and estragole in the volatile oil; proportions vary by cultivar and preparation.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Traditionally used after meals and in digestive preparations; also a culinary spice.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

Fennel tea may feel soothing for mild digestive discomfort, but it is not established as a treatment for serious gastrointestinal disease.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Clinical evidence is limited and often relates to specific mixtures or symptoms. Essential oil and concentrated extracts cannot be equated with food use.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Food use is common; infusion and powder are traditional. No universal medicinal dose stated without a verified formulation monograph.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Fennel fruit infusion and compound digestive powders; formulas vary.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
Avoid concentrated fennel/essential oil use in pregnancy and in children unless professionally advised. Estragole exposure and possible estrogenic effects warrant caution with concentrated products; allergy is possible.

Sources: Botanical/pharmacognosy reviews of Foeniculum vulgare; named nighaṇṭu edition needed for classical synonyms; API materials where applicable.

Nirgundī | Nirgundi

English: Five-leaved chaste tree • Hindi: Nirgundi • Gujarati: Nagod • Botanical: Vitex negundo L. • Family: Lamiaceae (older sources: Verbenaceae)

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Nirgundī is an aromatic shrub whose leaves and other parts are used in Ayurvedic external and internal preparations. The Sanskrit name is established; exact etymology is not asserted. Paryāya vary across nighaṇṭus. Scope: authenticated Vitex negundo; distinguish from Vitex agnus-castus and other Vitex species. Common forms include leaf paste, fomentation, decoction and medicated oil.

QUICK FACTS
Found across South and Southeast Asia, often in scrub and riverine habitats. Classical rasa-pañcaka varies by source; verify a specific nighaṇṭu entry rather than guessing. Traditionally described in vāta-related pain/swelling and skin contexts; plant part and preparation affect use.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES
Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu and other materia medica texts include Nirgundī; verify exact chapter/verse and plant part in the chosen edition.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS
Flavonoids such as casticin, iridoids, essential-oil constituents and other phenolics.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)
Traditionally used in external applications for pain and swelling and in selected respiratory or skin preparations.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS
Topical preparations may provide symptomatic comfort, but clinical evidence for specific conditions is limited.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE
Mostly preclinical and small studies; evidence is insufficient to establish broad therapeutic claims.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE
External paste/oil and internal preparations are traditional. No universal internal dose stated; use an authenticated product and qualified practitioner guidance.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS
Nirgundī taila and leaf-based external preparations; exact formulae vary.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
Skin irritation or allergy may occur. Internal medicinal-dose safety in pregnancy/lactation is insufficiently established; avoid self-treatment and check possible interactions with regular medicines.

Sources: Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu; pharmacognosy reviews of Vitex negundo; API/AFI references where applicable.

Bilva | Bael

English: Bael / Bengal quince • Hindi: Bel • Gujarati: Bilipatra • Botanical: Aegle marmelos (L.) Corrêa • Family: Rutaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Bilva is a small-to-medium tree whose fruit, root, leaves and other parts are used differently in Ayurvedic traditions. Unripe fruit is commonly associated with bowel-regulating preparations, while ripe fruit is used as food; these forms are not interchangeable. Bilva is a classical Sanskrit name. Paryāya lists vary by nighaṇṭu. Scope: authenticated Aegle marmelos and clearly specified plant part and maturity.

QUICK FACTS
Native to the Indian subcontinent and cultivated in South Asia. Rasa-pañcaka depends on the part and fruit maturity; classical descriptions often characterize unripe fruit as astringent and digestive. Do not apply one profile to root, leaf and ripe fruit alike.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Bilva appears in classical Saṃhitās and nighaṇṭus, including Bhāvaprakāśa; specific part-related indications should be tied to a named text and edition.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Marmelosin and other coumarins, alkaloids, tannins and volatile compounds; levels vary by part and maturity.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Traditionally used in digestive formulations, particularly preparations made from unripe fruit; other parts have separate traditional uses.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

Fruit is also a food. Traditional bowel uses should not delay assessment of persistent diarrhoea, dehydration or abdominal pain.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Much evidence is preclinical; clinical data are limited and often use specific extracts not equivalent to household preparations.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Unripe-fruit preparations and other part-specific forms differ. No universal dose stated; use only a formulation-specific reference and professional advice.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Bilvādi preparations and bael-fruit formulations; recipes vary by text and manufacturer.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
Incorrect plant-part or maturity selection can change effects. Use caution with diabetes medicines and during pregnancy/lactation; medicinal-dose safety is not established for all parts. Seek care for severe diarrhoea or dehydration.

Sources: Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu; API/AFI sources where applicable; pharmacognosy reviews of Aegle marmelos.

Aśvattha | Sacred fig

English: Sacred fig / peepal • Hindi: Peepal • Gujarati: Piplo • Botanical: Ficus religiosa L. • Family: Moraceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Aśvattha is a large fig tree with religious, ecological and traditional medicinal significance. Different texts refer to bark, leaves, fruit or latex for different purposes; these parts should not be treated as one drug. Aśvattha is the established Sanskrit name. Scope: Ficus religiosa only, distinguished from Vaṭa (Ficus benghalensis) and other Ficus species. Common traditional forms include bark decoction and topical preparations.

QUICK FACTS
Native to the Indian subcontinent and widely planted across South Asia. Exact rasa-pañcaka and karma should be verified from a named nighaṇṭu entry for the plant part; no universal profile is asserted here. Tree identity and part specification are essential.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Aśvattha appears in classical botanical and medicinal literature; verify specific medicinal claims in the chosen Saṃhitā/Nighaṇṭu edition. Do not conflate it with Vaṭa.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Reported constituents include tannins, flavonoids, sterols and other phenolics; profiles differ by plant part and extract.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Traditional sources describe part-specific external and internal uses; exact indications vary across texts and should be cited carefully.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

This is a culturally important tree with traditional uses, but modern clinical benefit for specific diseases is not established.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Primarily phytochemical and preclinical research; reliable clinical evidence is insufficient.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

No general dose stated because plant part, preparation and classical indication vary. Do not self-prescribe bark or latex internally.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Part-specific decoctions and topical preparations described in traditional practice; named formulations require source verification.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
Plant latex may irritate skin or eyes. Internal use can be unsafe if species or part is misidentified. Pregnancy/lactation safety and drug interactions are not established; consult a qualified practitioner.

Sources: Named classical editions for specific claims; botanical and pharmacognosy references for Ficus religiosa; API/AFI where applicable.

Vaṭa | Banyan

English: Banyan tree • Hindi: Bargad • Gujarati: Vad • Botanical: Ficus benghalensis L. • Family: Moraceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Vaṭa is a large evergreen-to-deciduous fig tree known for its aerial roots and broad canopy. Bark, aerial roots, leaves, latex and fruit have distinct traditional uses and must not be treated as interchangeable. Vaṭa is the classical Sanskrit name; it is different from Aśvattha (Ficus religiosa). Nighaṇṭu synonyms vary by edition. Scope: authenticated Ficus benghalensis and a clearly specified plant part; traditional forms include bark decoction and topical preparations.

QUICK FACTS
Native to the Indian subcontinent and widely planted in South Asia. Exact rasa-pañcaka should be verified for the selected plant part and nighaṇṭu edition; a single profile is not asserted here. Traditional uses are part-specific. Do not confuse Vaṭa with Aśvattha or other Ficus species.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Vaṭa is described in classical materia medica and botanical literature; cite specific Saṃhitā/Nighaṇṭu passages only after checking the selected edition and plant part.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Reported constituents include tannins, flavonoids, sterols and other phenolics; chemical profiles differ by bark, leaf, latex and aerial root.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Traditional sources describe part-specific uses, including astringent and topical applications. Precise indications should be tied to a verified classical source.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

A culturally important tree with a long history of traditional use; modern clinical benefit for specific diseases is not established.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Research is mainly phytochemical and preclinical. Reliable clinical evidence for specific therapeutic claims is insufficient.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

No general dose stated because plant part, preparation and intended use vary. Do not self-prescribe latex or internal bark preparations.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Part-specific decoctions and topical preparations are described in traditional practice; named formulations require verification.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
Latex can irritate skin and eyes; misidentification or incorrect plant-part use can be harmful. Pregnancy/lactation safety and drug interactions are not established. Consult a qualified practitioner.

Sources: Named classical editions for specific claims; botanical/pharmacognosy references for Ficus benghalensis; API/AFI where applicable.

Palāśa | Flame of the forest

Hindi: Dhak / Palash • Gujarati: Khakhro • Botanical: Butea monosperma (Lam.) Taub. • Family: Fabaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Palāśa is a deciduous tree known for bright orange-red flowers; its flowers, bark, seeds and other parts have distinct traditional uses. Palāśa is the established Sanskrit name. Classical synonyms vary by nighaṇṭu and should be checked against a named edition. Scope: authenticated Butea monosperma, with plant part and preparation specified; do not treat seed, bark and flower as equivalent drugs. Traditional forms include powders, decoctions and topical preparations.

QUICK FACTS
Habitat: Indian subcontinent, especially dry deciduous forests. Rasa-pañcaka depends on the part and source; a single universal profile is not asserted here. Classical actions are part-specific. Botanical identification and plant part must be confirmed before using a traditional indication.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Palāśa is described in classical materia medica and formulations. Verify exact Saṃhitā/Nighaṇṭu citations and synonyms against the edition being used; do not infer a verse reference from a general mention.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Reported constituents include flavonoids, chalcones such as butein, and other phenolic compounds; seed and flower chemistry differ.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Traditional sources describe part-specific uses, including seed-related anthelmintic contexts and flower/bark preparations. These uses require correct identification and professional guidance.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

Palāśa is a traditional multipurpose plant, but benefit depends on part, preparation and indication; it is not appropriate for unsupervised internal treatment.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Evidence is predominantly phytochemical and preclinical. High-quality clinical evidence for specific disease treatment is insufficient.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

No universal dose stated because plant parts and preparations differ and some uses carry toxicity risks. Use only a verified formulation reference and qualified practitioner advice.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Part-specific traditional powders, decoctions and topical preparations; named formulae must be verified in a classical source.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
Seeds and other parts may cause adverse effects if incorrectly used. Avoid self-medication, especially in pregnancy/lactation, children and chronic disease. Seek urgent care for severe vomiting, confusion or other acute toxicity symptoms.

Sources: Named classical editions for specific uses; botanical/pharmacognosy references for Butea monosperma; API/AFI where applicable.

Balā | Country mallow

English: Country mallow • Hindi: Bariyar / Bala • Gujarati: Khareti (regional) • Botanical: Sida cordifolia L. • Family: Malvaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Balā is a perennial herb used in Ayurveda, with the root and whole plant appearing in traditional preparations. The name Balā is associated with strength in Sanskrit usage, though etymological explanations vary. Paryāya differ by nighaṇṭu. Scope: authenticated Sida cordifolia; distinguish it from other Sida species and from Mahābalā, which may refer to a different botanical source in classical or commercial contexts. Forms include powder, decoction and medicated oils.

QUICK FACTS
Occurs in tropical/subtropical regions, including India. Classical descriptions commonly give madhura rasa, guru/snigdha qualities, śīta vīrya and madhura vipāka, but verify the selected source and plant part. Traditionally Vāta-śāmaka and balya/bṛṃhaṇa. Identity and formulation matter.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu and classical formulation texts include Balā; verify exact synonym lists and chapter references in the chosen edition.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Alkaloids including ephedrine-related compounds have been reported in some Sida cordifolia materials; composition and presence vary by source and analytical method.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Traditionally used in balya and Vāta-related formulations, including external oils and compound preparations.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

Its traditional role is as a strengthening ingredient in formulations; strong clinical evidence for many claimed outcomes is lacking.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Mostly preclinical evidence; clinical studies are limited. Potential sympathomimetic alkaloids make product quality and cardiovascular safety important.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

No universal dose supplied; use authenticated raw material and formulation-specific practitioner advice. Do not infer a dose from another Sida species.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Balā taila and Balā-containing compound preparations; formulae vary.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
Avoid unsupervised use in hypertension, arrhythmias, pregnancy/lactation and with stimulant medicines. Potential cardiovascular effects and adulteration/identity issues warrant caution.

Sources: Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu; pharmacognosy reviews of Sida cordifolia; API/AFI references where applicable.

TOXIC / SHODHANA REQUIRED
Potent pharmacological effects; no self-use dose. Only under supervision of a qualified Vaidya, in processed form. Verify classical category and shodhana in the selected authoritative text.

Sarpagandhā | Indian snakeroot

English: Indian snakeroot • Hindi: Sarpagandha • Gujarati: Sarpagandha • Botanical: Rauvolfia serpentina (L.) Benth. ex Kurz • Family: Apocynaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Sarpagandhā is a medicinal shrub whose root contains potent indole alkaloids and has been used in classical and modern medicine for specific indications. The Sanskrit name is established. It is a pharmacologically potent plant and must not be self-prescribed. Classical sources classify and use it in particular contexts; do not infer a modern dose from historical mention. Scope: authenticated root of Rauvolfia serpentina, distinct from other Rauvolfia species and commercial substitutes.

QUICK FACTS
Found in South and Southeast Asia, including forest understory habitats. Classical rasa-pañcaka and exact Visha/Upavisha category should be checked in the specific nighaṇṭu/rasashastra edition; data not asserted here without verified source. Alkaloid-rich root has strong physiological effects.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Verify Sarpagandhā in the selected Nighaṇṭu and relevant Rasashastra texts before assigning a Visha/Upavisha label or quoting a shodhana procedure. Modern pharmacology references confirm potent alkaloids.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Reserpine, ajmaline, ajmalicine and other indole alkaloids; amounts vary with species, root material and processing.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Historically used for selected conditions including high blood pressure and agitation, but contemporary use requires medical oversight because of significant adverse effects and interactions.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

Some Rauvolfia alkaloids have established pharmacological activity; the raw herb is not a safe substitute for standardized prescription medicines.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Reserpine has known pharmacological effects, but it can cause substantial adverse effects. Modern treatment decisions should be made by a licensed clinician.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

No self-use dose. Only under supervision of a qualified Vaidya and/or prescribing clinician, in an authenticated and appropriately processed product.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Historical and compound preparations exist; do not use raw root or unverified products.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
May cause hypotension, bradycardia, depression, sedation and serious interactions with antihypertensives, antidepressants and other medicines. Pregnancy/lactation and psychiatric/cardiovascular conditions require strict professional review. Poisoning signs may include fainting, very slow pulse, severe weakness or altered mental state—seek emergency care.

Sources: Pharmacology references for Rauvolfia alkaloids; classical sources require edition-specific verification; API/AFI where applicable.

Kuṭaja | Kurchi

English: Kurchi / conessi • Hindi: Kutaj • Gujarati: Indrajav (regional; may also refer to seeds) • Botanical: Holarrhena pubescens Wall. ex G.Don (syn. H. antidysenterica) • Family: Apocynaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Kuṭaja is a small tree whose bark and seeds are used in Ayurvedic materia medica, especially in traditional formulations for bowel disorders. The Sanskrit name is established; Indrayava commonly refers to its seeds in materia-medica usage. Scope: distinguish bark (Kuṭaja tvak) from seeds (Indrayava) and authenticate Holarrhena pubescens; common-name use can vary. Forms include powder, decoction and compound formulations.

QUICK FACTS
Occurs in South Asia and parts of Southeast Asia, including dry forests. Classical rasa-pañcaka is commonly described with tikta/kaṣāya elements; verify exact profile against the chosen nighaṇṭu. Traditionally used in Kapha-Pitta and bowel-related contexts; preparation and plant part matter.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Kuṭaja and Indrayava are listed in classical nighaṇṭus and formulation texts. Verify exact chapter and ingredient identity for a specific formula.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Steroidal alkaloids including conessine and related alkaloids; concentrations vary by bark/seed and extraction.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Traditionally used in formulations for atisāra and pravāhikā-type bowel complaints. Persistent diarrhoea may require medical assessment and fluid replacement.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

Traditional formulations may be used for selected bowel symptoms, but severe diarrhoea, blood in stool or dehydration needs prompt clinical care.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Preclinical and limited clinical research exists; robust evidence for many indications is insufficient and products are not interchangeable.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Powder/decoction and compound formulations differ. No universal dose stated; follow the exact formulation reference and practitioner advice.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Kuṭajāriṣṭa and other Kuṭaja-containing preparations; ingredient lists vary by formulation.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
May cause gastrointestinal effects and interact with medicines; safety in pregnancy/lactation is not well established. Seek care for blood in stool, fever, severe pain or dehydration.

Sources: Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu; AFI for specific formulations where listed; pharmacognosy reviews of Holarrhena pubescens.

Kuṭkī | Picrorhiza

English: Picrorhiza • Hindi: Kutki • Gujarati: Kutki • Botanical: Picrorhiza kurroa Royle ex Benth. • Family: Plantaginaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Kuṭkī is a small perennial herb of Himalayan alpine/subalpine habitats; the rhizome and roots are used as an Ayurvedic drug. The Sanskrit name is established in materia medica. Paryāya lists vary by text. Scope: authenticated Picrorhiza kurroa; do not substitute other bitter rhizomes sold as Kutki. Forms include powder, decoction and extracts.

QUICK FACTS
Native to the western Himalaya and adjoining high-altitude regions. Classical rasa-pañcaka is commonly described as tikta and cooling, but exact values should be verified against the chosen nighaṇṭu. Traditionally used in Pitta-related and liver/digestive contexts; traditional use does not establish efficacy.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Kuṭkī appears in classical materia medica and later formularies; verify the exact nighaṇṭu entry and API identity standards for the relevant plant part.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Iridoid glycosides including picroside I, picroside II and kutkoside; concentrations vary by material and extraction.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Traditionally used in bitter digestive preparations and for selected liver-related indications. Do not stop prescribed liver treatment.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

Its bitter constituents have been studied experimentally, but clinical benefits remain uncertain.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Mostly preclinical and small/limited clinical studies; high-quality evidence for treating liver disease is insufficient.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Rhizome/root powder and extracts differ. No universal dose stated; use a verified monograph and clinician guidance, particularly for liver disease.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Kuṭkī-containing powders and compound formulations; exact recipes vary.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
May cause gastrointestinal effects. Avoid unsupervised use in pregnancy/lactation and with liver disease or multiple medicines; product identity and contamination are concerns.

Sources: API/PCIM&H; monographs where applicable; pharmacognosy reviews of Picrorhiza kurroa; named nighaṇṭu edition for classical attributes.

Śaṅkhapuṣpī | Shankhpushpi

English: Shankhpushpi (regional common name) • Hindi: Shankhpushpi • Botanical identity varies in commerce; Convolvulus pluricaulis Choisy is a commonly cited source • Family: Convolvulaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Śaṅkhapuṣpī is a traditional medhya herb name, but its botanical identity is not uniform across all regional and commercial sources. Convolvulus pluricaulis is commonly cited; Clitoria ternatea and Evolvulus alsinoides have also been associated with similar market names in some settings. This page focuses on identity control and does not treat these species as interchangeable. Verify the exact botanical source before applying classical properties, dose or evidence.

QUICK FACTS
Habitat and distribution depend on the species supplied. Rasa-pañcaka and karma must be tied to the authenticated botanical identity and source text; where not confirmed, data not established. Products labelled only “Shankhpushpi” may not be botanically equivalent.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Check the specific Śaṅkhapuṣpī entry in the selected Bhāvaprakāśa/Dhanvantari Nighaṇṭu edition and applicable pharmacopoeial monograph. Do not assign one species' references to another.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Constituents vary by species; studies of Convolvulus pluricaulis report alkaloids, flavonoids and other compounds, but not all commercial products match that species.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Traditionally used in medhya formulations for memory and mental calm; exact classical attribution depends on species and text.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

The main practical benefit of correct identification is avoiding inappropriate transfer of claims and doses between different plants.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Clinical evidence is limited and often affected by small studies, mixed formulations and uncertain species authentication.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

No dose for an unidentified product. Authenticate species and plant part first, then use the relevant monograph and qualified practitioner guidance.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Shankhpushpi syrups, powders and compound medhya formulations exist; check the Latin binomial and full ingredient list.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
Do not assume all products are equivalent. Pregnancy/lactation safety, drug interactions and long-term safety vary by species and preparation; avoid unsupervised use.

Sources: Applicable API/PCIM&H; monographs; botanical references for Convolvulus pluricaulis and related species; named nighaṇṭu edition required.

Aparājitā | Butterfly pea

English: Butterfly pea • Hindi: Aparajita • Gujarati: Gokarni (regional) • Botanical: Clitoria ternatea L. • Family: Fabaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Aparājitā is a climbing herb with blue or white flowers; roots, seeds and flowers have different traditional uses. The Sanskrit name is established in Ayurveda. Scope: authenticated Clitoria ternatea; do not confuse it with Śaṅkhapuṣpī-labelled products from other species. Traditional forms include root/seed preparations and flower infusions, but part-specific use must be verified in the source text.

QUICK FACTS
Tropical South and Southeast Asia; cultivated as an ornamental and food/tea plant. Classical rasa-pañcaka and indications vary by text and part; exact values should be checked in a named nighaṇṭu. Flower tea use is not equivalent to medicinal root/seed use.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Verify Aparājitā in the selected Bhāvaprakāśa/Dhanvantari Nighaṇṭu and relevant classical formulation texts; avoid transferring references from Śaṅkhapuṣpī.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Anthocyanins such as ternatins in blue flowers; seeds and roots have distinct constituent profiles.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Traditionally used in selected formulations; flowers are also used as a food-colouring infusion in some cultures.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

Flower infusion provides colour and has been studied for antioxidant activity, but clinical health benefits are not established.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Evidence is mostly preclinical; well-designed clinical trials are limited.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Food infusion and medicinal preparations differ. No universal therapeutic dose stated; use practitioner guidance for internal medicinal preparations.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Flower infusion and part-specific traditional preparations; formulae vary.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
Avoid medicinal-dose use during pregnancy/lactation without professional advice. Seed/root preparations are not interchangeable with flower tea; allergic reactions and interactions are insufficiently characterized.

Sources: Botanical/pharmacognosy reviews of Clitoria ternatea; named classical nighaṇṭu editions; API/AFI where applicable.

Vacā | Sweet flag

English: Sweet flag • Hindi: Bach • Gujarati: Vach • Botanical: Acorus calamus L. • Family: Acoraceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Vacā is a perennial wetland plant whose rhizome is used in Ayurvedic materia medica. The Sanskrit name is established; classical descriptions associate it with specific digestive and medhya contexts. Scope: authenticated Acorus calamus rhizome; chemotypes differ in β-asarone content, and this has major safety implications. Do not treat all sweet-flag products as chemically equivalent. Traditional forms include powder and compound preparations.

QUICK FACTS
Occurs in wetlands across parts of Asia and other regions. Classical rasa-pañcaka is often described as pungent/bitter and heating, but verify the selected source. Dosha action and use depend on preparation. β-Asarone content varies by cytotype and product.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Vacā is described in classical Saṃhitās and nighaṇṭus; verify exact citations and shodhana instructions against the selected edition. Modern toxicology literature is essential for safety context.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Volatile oils including α- and β-asarone; β-asarone content is highly variable and associated with toxicological concerns.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Traditionally used in selected digestive, speech/voice and medhya formulations; historical use does not establish modern safety.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

No self-treatment recommendation: the main concern is balancing historical use against known chemotype-dependent safety risks.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Pharmacological research is mainly preclinical. β-Asarone has genotoxicity/carcinogenicity concerns in experimental data; safety varies by product and jurisdiction.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

No self-use dose provided. Avoid oral use of unverified Vacā products; consult a qualified practitioner and applicable regulatory guidance.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Historical powders and compound formulations exist; use only a verified product with documented identity and safety specifications.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
Potential β-asarone toxicity is a significant concern. Avoid unsupervised oral use, especially in pregnancy/lactation and children. If ingestion is followed by vomiting, dizziness, confusion or other acute symptoms, seek urgent medical advice.

Sources: Classical editions for traditional indications; toxicology reviews of Acorus calamus/β-asarone; applicable pharmacopoeial and regulatory standards.

Japa | Hibiscus

English: China rose / Hibiscus • Hindi: Gudhal • Gujarati: Jasu • Botanical: Hibiscus rosa-sinensis L. • Family: Malvaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Japa commonly refers to the ornamental hibiscus, Hibiscus rosa-sinensis, whose flowers and leaves are used in regional traditional preparations and hair-care products. Common-name usage can vary, and it should not be confused with Hibiscus sabdariffa (roselle), a different species used for beverages. Classical Sanskrit synonym lists and exact etymology should be verified in a named nighaṇṭu. Scope: authenticated H. rosa-sinensis and specified plant part.

QUICK FACTS
Widely cultivated in tropical and subtropical regions. Classical rasa-pañcaka and therapeutic karma should be verified from the chosen text; data not established here for a universal profile. Flower, leaf and root preparations are not interchangeable.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Verify Japa in the selected Bhāvaprakāśa/Dhanvantari Nighaṇṭu edition and check the species used by that source; do not transfer evidence from H. sabdariffa.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Anthocyanins and other flavonoids in flowers; constituents vary by cultivar and plant part.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Regional traditional topical use for hair and skin; other uses are source- and preparation-specific.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

May be used as a traditional cosmetic ingredient, but clinical evidence for hair growth or systemic benefits is limited.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Mostly laboratory and preliminary research; robust clinical trials for specific health claims are lacking.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Topical preparations and regional traditional uses vary. No universal internal dose stated; avoid ingestion of unidentified ornamental plant material.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Flower/leaf pastes, oils and cosmetic preparations; exact recipes vary.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
Possible skin allergy. Avoid medicinal internal use during pregnancy/lactation without qualified guidance; verify species and pesticide-free source for topical use.

Sources: Botanical references for Hibiscus rosa-sinensis; named nighaṇṭu editions; pharmacognosy reviews.

Pudīnā | Mint

English: Mint (common culinary mint) • Hindi: Pudina • Gujarati: Fudino • Botanical: Mentha spicata L. is common spearmint; Mentha × piperita is peppermint • Family: Lamiaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Pudīnā is a common name for aromatic Mentha species used as food and in traditional digestive preparations. The name alone does not establish the botanical species: spearmint (Mentha spicata) and peppermint (Mentha × piperita) differ in chemistry. This entry focuses on culinary spearmint where identified. Sanskrit synonym lists and classical rasa-pañcaka should be verified against a named nighaṇṭu and the exact species; do not assign one species' properties to another.

QUICK FACTS
Cultivated widely in temperate and subtropical regions. Classical properties vary by species and source; data not established here for a universal Ayurvedic profile. Culinary leaves, dried leaf and essential oil are distinct exposure forms.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Check the exact species and the Pudīnā/Mentha entry in the selected nighaṇṭu; common culinary use should not be presented as a classical textual citation without verification.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Spearmint commonly contains carvone and limonene; peppermint commonly contains menthol and menthone. Essential-oil composition differs significantly by species.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Fresh leaves and infusions are used as food and traditionally for mild digestive comfort.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

Mint can add flavour and may feel soothing after meals; it is not an established treatment for persistent gastrointestinal symptoms.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Some clinical evidence exists for specific peppermint-oil preparations in irritable bowel syndrome, but this cannot be generalized to spearmint leaves or ordinary mint tea.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Culinary use differs from concentrated essential oils. No universal medicinal dose stated; follow product-specific guidance and do not ingest essential oil without professional direction.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Fresh leaves, infusion, dried leaf and species-specific essential-oil products.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
Peppermint oil can worsen reflux and may interact with some medicines; essential oils can be harmful if swallowed incorrectly. Pregnancy/lactation safety depends on product and dose. Avoid use in infants without medical advice.

Sources: Botanical references for Mentha species; clinical reviews of peppermint oil; named nighaṇṭu edition needed for classical properties.

Pippalīmūla | Long pepper root

English: Long pepper root • Hindi: Pippali mool • Botanical: Piper longum L. (root) • Family: Piperaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Pippalīmūla is the root of Piper longum used as a distinct Ayurvedic drug from Pippalī fruit. Although both come from the same species, plant part changes composition and traditional application. The Sanskrit name is established. Scope: authenticated root only; do not use fruit data or doses as a substitute. Classical synonyms and specific indications should be checked against the selected nighaṇṭu and formulation text.

QUICK FACTS
Plant source: P. longum, a climbing plant of South/Southeast Asia. Rasa-pañcaka and karma can differ from the fruit; exact values should be verified in a named classical source. Do not transfer Pippalī-fruit properties or dosage to Pippalīmūla.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Check Pippalīmūla separately from Pippalī in Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu and the relevant formulation texts; cite chapter/verse only after edition-level verification.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Root chemistry differs from fruit; piperine and related amides may be present, with composition dependent on material and extraction.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Used in selected traditional digestive and compound formulations; specific indications vary by text and preparation.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

Part-specific identification helps prevent confusing root and fruit medicines.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Modern clinical evidence specifically for Pippalīmūla is limited; findings on Pippalī fruit or isolated piperine should not be transferred directly.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

No universal dose stated. Use only a verified formula or monograph and a qualified practitioner; root and fruit are not dose-equivalent.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Pippalīmūla powder and selected compound formulations; recipes vary.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
Possible gastrointestinal irritation and drug interactions are not well characterized. Avoid self-prescribing during pregnancy/lactation or with regular medicines.

Sources: Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu and formulation texts (verify edition); pharmacognosy references for Piper longum.

Elā | Cardamom

English: Green cardamom • Hindi: Chhoti elaichi • Gujarati: Elchi • Botanical: Elettaria cardamomum (L.) Maton • Family: Zingiberaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Elā is an aromatic perennial whose dried capsules and seeds are used as a spice and in traditional Ayurvedic formulations. Elā is the established Sanskrit name. Paryāya lists differ by nighaṇṭu. Scope: green cardamom (Elettaria cardamomum); distinguish it from large/black cardamom (Amomum subulatum), which is a different species. Forms include whole seed, powder, infusion and compound preparations.

QUICK FACTS
Cultivated in humid tropical areas, including southern India. Classical descriptions commonly emphasize aromatic, digestive and breath-freshening actions; verify exact rasa-pañcaka against the chosen text. Fruit capsules, seeds and essential oil are different preparations.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Elā appears in classical nighaṇṭus and many formulations; confirm the precise entry and synonyms in the chosen Bhāvaprakāśa/Dhanvantari edition.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Volatile oils including 1,8-cineole and α-terpinyl acetate; composition varies with cultivar and processing.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Traditional use as a digestive spice, breath-freshener and ingredient in compound formulations.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

Useful as a flavouring spice; evidence for treating disease beyond culinary use is limited.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Mostly laboratory and small clinical studies; robust evidence for specific therapeutic claims is insufficient.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Culinary use differs from concentrated essential oil. No universal medicinal dose stated; follow the specific formulation and practitioner guidance.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Elā powder and compound digestive or aromatic preparations; recipes vary.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
Food amounts are generally tolerated; allergy or gastrointestinal symptoms may occur. Do not ingest essential oil undiluted. Pregnancy/lactation safety of concentrated extracts is insufficiently established.

Sources: Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu; botanical/pharmacognosy references for Elettaria cardamomum; API/AFI where applicable.

Tvak | Cinnamon bark

English: Ceylon cinnamon (identity must be specified) • Hindi: Dalchini • Gujarati: Taj • Botanical: Cinnamomum verum J.Presl; commercial cassia species may also be sold as cinnamon • Family: Lauraceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Tvak refers to aromatic bark used as a spice and in traditional formulations. “Cinnamon” in trade can mean Cinnamomum verum or cassia species such as C. cassia/C. aromaticum, which differ in coumarin content and safety. Sanskrit name usage and synonyms must be verified in the chosen nighaṇṭu. Scope: identify the exact species and bark source; do not treat all market cinnamon as chemically identical.

QUICK FACTS
Cinnamon trees grow in tropical Asia; C. verum is strongly associated with Sri Lanka. Classical rasa-pañcaka should be checked against a specific source. Bark powder, aqueous extract and essential oil are different exposures.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Verify Tvak/Dāru-tvāk entries in the selected nighaṇṭu and formulation text. Modern trade identity matters because cassia cinnamon may contain substantially more coumarin than C. verum.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Cinnamaldehyde and other volatile-oil constituents; coumarin levels vary by species, especially between Ceylon cinnamon and cassia.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Traditional aromatic digestive and compound formulations; also a common culinary spice.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

Culinary use adds flavour. Evidence for cinnamon supplements improving metabolic outcomes is inconsistent and does not establish treatment of diabetes.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Clinical studies show mixed results for glycaemic and lipid measures; study products and species vary. Cassia-associated coumarin can pose liver risk with high/prolonged exposure.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Food use differs from medicinal supplements and essential oil. No universal dose stated; identify the species and follow clinician advice for concentrated products.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Tvak powder and aromatic compound formulations; recipes and species specifications vary.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
Caution with liver disease, anticoagulants and glucose-lowering medicines. Avoid prolonged high-dose cassia supplements; essential oil can irritate or be toxic if misused. Pregnancy/lactation safety of concentrated products is uncertain.

Sources: Botanical/pharmacognosy reviews of Cinnamomum species; clinical reviews of cinnamon supplements; named nighaṇṭu edition for classical properties.

Kṛṣṇa-jīraka | Black cumin — identity warning

Common-name caution • “Black cumin” may mean Nigella sativa L. or Bunium persicum; these are different plants • Nigella family: Ranunculaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
“Black cumin” is an ambiguous market name. Nigella sativa is commonly sold as black seed/black cumin, while Bunium persicum is also called black cumin or kala jeera in some regions. They are botanically distinct and should not share one monograph, dose or evidence base. This entry focuses on identity control for Nigella sativa only and does not claim that every Sanskrit reference to Kṛṣṇa-jīraka identifies this species. Confirm Latin binomial and plant part.

QUICK FACTS
Nigella sativa is cultivated in parts of West and South Asia. Classical rasa-pañcaka and Sanskrit synonym attribution require a named text and verified botanical identification; data not established here. Seed, seed oil and extracts differ.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Do not assign a Kṛṣṇa-jīraka citation without checking the specific nighaṇṭu and botanical source. Modern Nigella sativa evidence is separate from Bunium persicum.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Nigella sativa seed contains thymoquinone and other volatile-oil constituents; Bunium persicum has a different volatile-oil profile.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Nigella seed is used as a culinary spice and in various traditional systems; specific Ayurvedic attribution depends on source identity.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

The main point is to prevent substitution and evidence transfer between two different plants.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Small clinical trials of Nigella sativa exist for selected outcomes, but evidence is heterogeneous and does not establish broad disease treatment.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

No dose for an unidentified “black cumin” product. Verify species, plant part and preparation first; concentrated oils require professional guidance.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Whole seed, powder, oil and extracts are not interchangeable.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
Possible allergy and gastrointestinal effects; interactions with glucose-lowering, blood-pressure or anticoagulant medicines are possible. Pregnancy/lactation safety for medicinal-dose products is insufficiently established.

Sources: Botanical references for Nigella sativa and Bunium persicum; clinical reviews of Nigella sativa; named nighaṇṭu edition required for classical identity.

Śigru | Moringa

English: Drumstick tree / moringa • Hindi: Sahjan • Gujarati: Saragvo • Botanical: Moringa oleifera Lam. • Family: Moringaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Śigru is a fast-growing tree whose leaves, pods, seeds, bark and roots have different food and traditional uses. Śigru is a classical name, but exact part-specific descriptions should be checked against the selected nighaṇṭu. Scope: authenticated Moringa oleifera; leaf powder, edible pods, seed oil and root/bark preparations are not interchangeable. Food use of leaves and pods differs from medicinal-dose products.

QUICK FACTS
Native to South Asia and cultivated widely in tropical regions. Classical rasa-pañcaka is often described as pungent and heating, but verify the chosen source and part. Dosha/karma depend on preparation. Leaves and pods are nutrient-rich foods; roots/bark warrant greater caution.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Check Śigru in Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu and the relevant API/AFI references; plant-part attribution should be explicit.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Leaves contain carotenoids, polyphenols and glucosinolates; seeds contain oil and other constituents. Composition varies with cultivar and processing.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Leaves and pods are used as foods; traditional sources also describe part-specific medicinal uses.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

Edible leaves and pods can contribute nutrients to a balanced diet. Supplements are not a replacement for prescribed treatment.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Nutritional and preclinical research is substantial, but clinical evidence for disease treatment remains limited and product-specific.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Food portions differ from extracts and medicinal preparations. No universal medicinal dose stated; avoid unsupervised root/bark use.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Cooked leaves/pods, leaf powder, seed oil and compound preparations.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
Use extra caution with root and bark products; avoid medicinal-dose use during pregnancy unless a qualified clinician advises otherwise. Possible interactions with glucose- or blood-pressure-lowering medicines. Wash and cook food plant parts appropriately.

Sources: Botanical/pharmacognosy reviews of Moringa oleifera; named nighaṇṭu edition; API/AFI where applicable.

Methikā | Fenugreek

English: Fenugreek • Hindi: Methi • Gujarati: Methi • Botanical: Trigonella foenum-graecum L. • Family: Fabaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Methikā is an annual herb whose seeds and leaves are used as food and in traditional preparations. The Sanskrit name is established in Ayurvedic materia medica. Scope: distinguish fresh leaves, dried leaves and seeds, as their composition and use differ. Forms include culinary greens, seed powder, infusion and extracts. Classical synonyms and rasa-pañcaka should be checked against the selected nighaṇṭu edition.

QUICK FACTS
Cultivated in India and other temperate/subtropical regions. Classical attributes are source-dependent; verify a specific entry rather than inferring properties from modern nutritional data. Seeds contain mucilage and saponins; leaves are commonly eaten as vegetables.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Verify Methikā in the chosen Bhāvaprakāśa/Dhanvantari Nighaṇṭu edition and relevant formulation text before citing exact synonyms or verse numbers.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Galactomannan fibre, steroidal saponins, 4-hydroxyisoleucine and trigonelline have been reported; composition differs between seeds and leaves.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Food use and traditional digestive/metabolic preparations; seed-based traditional use should not be equated with leaf consumption.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

Fenugreek is a fibre-containing food. Evidence that supplements improve glucose or lipid measures is mixed and not a replacement for medical care.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Small clinical studies report possible modest effects on glycaemic measures, but study quality, dose and products vary.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Culinary seed/leaf use differs from concentrated supplements. No universal medicinal dose stated; monitor glucose if using supplements with diabetes medicines.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Methi seeds, leaf preparations and compound powders.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
May cause gas, diarrhoea or allergy, especially in people allergic to legumes. Supplements can lower blood glucose and interact with anticoagulants. Avoid medicinal-dose supplements during pregnancy unless medically directed.

Sources: Botanical/pharmacognosy reviews of Trigonella foenum-graecum; clinical reviews of fenugreek; named nighaṇṭu edition for classical attributes.

Kari-patta | Curry leaf

English: Curry leaf • Hindi: Kadi patta • Gujarati: Mitho limdo • Botanical: Murraya koenigii (L.) Spreng. • Family: Rutaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Curry leaf is an aromatic tree or shrub whose fresh leaves are widely used as a culinary seasoning and in regional traditional preparations. Common-name use is more stable than classical synonym attribution; verify Sanskrit names against a named nighaṇṭu before citing them. Scope: authenticated Murraya koenigii leaves; distinguish from neem (Azadirachta indica), which may also be called “limdo” in Gujarati but is a different plant. Forms include fresh leaves, dried leaf powder and extracts.

QUICK FACTS
Native to the Indian subcontinent and cultivated widely in South Asia. Classical rasa-pañcaka and dosha action are not asserted without a verified species-specific source. Food use is common; extracts and essential oils are different exposures.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

A precise classical citation for Murraya koenigii should be verified in the selected text; do not use neem references because of vernacular-name overlap.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Carbazole alkaloids such as mahanimbine and koenimbine, plus volatile oils and other phytochemicals.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Primarily a culinary herb; regional traditional uses exist but should be tied to a source and preparation.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

Fresh leaves contribute flavour and are part of many diets. Therapeutic claims for concentrated extracts remain unproven.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Mostly preclinical research; robust human clinical evidence for specific disease treatment is insufficient.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Culinary use is distinct from medicinal extracts. No universal medicinal dose stated.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Fresh leaves, dried powder and regional preparations.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
Food use is generally tolerated; allergy or gastrointestinal upset is possible. Concentrated extract safety and interactions are insufficiently established, especially in pregnancy/lactation.

Sources: Botanical/pharmacognosy references for Murraya koenigii; named nighaṇṭu edition needed for classical attribution.

Kalamegha | Andrographis

English: King of bitters • Hindi: Kalmegh • Gujarati: Kariyatu (regional) • Botanical: Andrographis paniculata (Burm.f.) Nees • Family: Acanthaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Kalamegha is an annual herb with intensely bitter aerial parts used in Ayurvedic and other South Asian materia medica. The Sanskrit name is established in later materia-medica usage; synonyms and classical textual scope should be checked against a named source. Scope: authenticated Andrographis paniculata; do not confuse with other bitter herbs sold under regional names. Forms include powder, decoction and standardized extracts.

QUICK FACTS
Native to South Asia and cultivated in tropical regions. Bitter taste is prominent; exact rasa-pañcaka and classical karma should be verified in the chosen nighaṇṭu. Extracts standardized for andrographolides differ from whole-plant preparations.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Verify Kalamegha in the selected nighaṇṭu and applicable pharmacopoeial monograph; avoid claiming a Saṃhitā reference without a traceable citation.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Andrographolide and related diterpenoid lactones; content varies by plant part, harvest and extraction.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Traditionally used in bitter digestive and fever-related preparations; persistent fever requires medical assessment.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

A bitter herb with laboratory-studied constituents; not a substitute for diagnosis or treatment of infection.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Some clinical research on Andrographis extracts concerns upper-respiratory symptoms, but formulations and trial quality vary. Evidence cannot be generalized to all products.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Whole-herb powder and standardized extracts are not dose-equivalent. No universal dose stated; follow a verified product monograph and practitioner advice.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Kalamegha powder, decoctions and standardized extracts; compound recipes vary.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
May cause gastrointestinal effects and allergic reactions. Avoid during pregnancy; possible interactions with anticoagulants, blood-pressure or immune-modulating medicines require review. Stop and seek care for severe allergy or persistent symptoms.

Sources: Pharmacopoeial/botanical references for Andrographis paniculata; systematic reviews of Andrographis for respiratory symptoms; named nighaṇṭu edition.

Guḍmār | Gymnema

English: Gymnema / sugar destroyer (traditional epithet) • Hindi: Gurmar • Gujarati: Madhunashini (regional) • Botanical: Gymnema sylvestre (Retz.) R.Br. ex Sm. • Family: Apocynaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Guḍmār is a climbing woody plant whose leaves are used in traditional preparations, particularly in metabolic contexts. The name is popularly glossed as “sugar destroyer,” but this is a traditional epithet rather than a guarantee of clinical effect. Scope: authenticated Gymnema sylvestre leaves; products vary in gymnemic-acid content and extraction. Do not treat it as a replacement for diabetes care.

QUICK FACTS
Native to tropical parts of India and nearby regions. Classical rasa-pañcaka should be verified against a named nighaṇṭu; modern glucose-related research does not establish classical properties. Leaves, powders and standardized extracts differ.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Verify Guḍmār/Meṣaśṛṅgī entries in the chosen nighaṇṭu and the applicable pharmacopoeial monograph; avoid unsupported verse citations.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Gymnemic acids, gymnemasaponins and other triterpenoid saponins; concentrations vary by extract.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Traditional use in metabolic formulations; modern use is often marketed for blood-glucose support.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

May influence glucose measures, but unsupervised use can complicate diabetes management.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Small clinical studies suggest possible glucose-lowering effects, but evidence quality and product consistency are limited.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

No universal dose stated. Do not start or stop diabetes medicines based on this herb; clinician supervision and glucose monitoring are essential.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Leaf powder, capsules and standardized extracts; composition varies widely.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
May cause hypoglycaemia when combined with diabetes medicines. Avoid during pregnancy/lactation due to insufficient safety data. Discuss use with a clinician and monitor glucose closely.

Sources: Botanical/pharmacognosy reviews of Gymnema sylvestre; clinical reviews of glucose effects; named nighaṇṭu/API entry for classical identity.

Punarnavā | Spreading hogweed

English: Spreading hogweed • Hindi: Punarnava • Gujarati: Satodi (regional) • Botanical: Boerhavia diffusa L. • Family: Nyctaginaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE
Punarnavā is a creeping perennial herb whose roots and whole plant are used in Ayurvedic materia medica. The Sanskrit name is established and commonly linked in traditional explanations with “renewing” or “becoming new again,” though a precise etymology should be treated cautiously. Paryāya lists vary by nighaṇṭu. Scope: authenticated Boerhavia diffusa; distinguish it from other Boerhavia species and market substitutes. Forms include powder, decoction, fresh juice and compound preparations.

QUICK FACTS
Occurs in tropical/subtropical regions, including India. Classical descriptions commonly include tikta/kaṣāya elements and use in urinary/fluid-related contexts, but verify the chosen source and plant part. Dosha action and karma vary by preparation.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Punarnavā appears in classical nighaṇṭus and formulation texts; verify the exact edition and part-specific indication before citing chapter/verse.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Punarnavine, rotenoid-related compounds and other alkaloids/phenolics have been reported; chemistry depends on part and extract.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Traditionally used in urinary and swelling-related formulations; swelling can indicate serious disease and needs medical evaluation.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

Its traditional use includes fluid-related complaints, but it is not a substitute for assessment of kidney, heart or liver disease.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Evidence is mainly preclinical with limited human research; strong clinical evidence for specific diseases is insufficient.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Root/whole-plant powder, juice and decoction differ. No universal dose stated; use a verified formulation and practitioner advice, especially with diuretics.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Punarnavāṣṭaka kvātha and other Punarnavā-containing formulations; recipes vary by source.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS
Possible diuretic or blood-pressure/glucose effects; interactions with diuretics and antihypertensives are possible. Avoid unsupervised use in pregnancy/lactation and kidney/heart disease.

Sources: Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu; API/AFI where applicable; pharmacognosy reviews of Boerhavia diffusa.

Kumārī | Aloe vera

Aloe vera • Hindi: Ghritkumari • Botanical: Aloe vera (L.) Burm.f. (syn. Aloe barbadensis Mill.) • Family: Asphodelaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE

Kumārī refers to Aloe vera in modern Ayurvedic trade, especially the inner leaf gel. Distinguish the clear inner gel from yellow latex under the leaf rind: these have different constituents, effects and risks. Classical name-to-species mappings should be checked against the selected materia medica.

QUICK FACTS

Succulent with thick fleshy leaves. Plant part: leaf inner gel or processed preparations; latex is a potent stimulant laxative and is not interchangeable with gel. Classical rasa-pañcaka details are text-dependent.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Kumārī appears in Ayurvedic nighaṇṭus and formulations; verify precise synonyms and verse citations in a specified edition of Bhāvaprakāśa Nighaṇṭu and related sources.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Inner gel contains polysaccharides including acemannan; latex contains hydroxyanthracene derivatives such as aloin.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Used traditionally in selected skin-care, digestive and women’s-health preparations; specific indications depend on preparation and source.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

Topical gel may soothe some minor skin irritation; clinical benefit varies by condition and product quality.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Evidence for topical wound or burn outcomes is mixed and condition-specific. Oral aloe products have heterogeneous composition and uncertain efficacy.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Topical stabilized gel; commercial juices; classical formulations. No universal oral dose: gel, whole-leaf extract and latex are not equivalent.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Kumaryasava is a named classical formulation; composition and indications must be verified in the relevant formulary.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS

Avoid oral aloe latex/whole-leaf laxative products without professional advice: cramping, diarrhea, electrolyte depletion and interactions are possible. Pregnancy: avoid medicinal oral use. Patch-test topical products; seek care for serious burns.

SOURCES

NCCIH Aloe Vera overview; EMA herbal monographs on aloe latex; Ayurvedic Formulary of India (Kumaryasava, edition verification).

Bhṛṅgarāja | False daisy

English: False daisy • Hindi: Bhringraj • Botanical: Eclipta prostrata (L.) L. (syn. Eclipta alba) • Family: Asteraceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE

Bhṛṅgarāja is a herb commonly identified as Eclipta prostrata. It is used in Ayurvedic hair/scalp oils and compound preparations. Scope: authenticated aerial plant parts; trade substitutions and taxonomic synonyms require checking.

QUICK FACTS

Small herb often found in moist habitats. Plant part: whole plant or aerial parts. Exact rasa-pañcaka and karma should be verified in the selected nighaṇṭu.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Bhṛṅgarāja entries are found in Ayurvedic materia medica and oil-formulation traditions; verify specific classical verse and formula against an identified edition.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Coumestans including wedelolactone and demethylwedelolactone; flavonoids and other phenolics.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Traditionally used in hair and scalp preparations and in selected liver-related compound medicines; these are historical uses, not established clinical indications.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

Recognizable ingredient in traditional scalp-care oils; benefits for hair growth in humans are not firmly established.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Mainly preclinical investigations; reliable human trials are insufficient to confirm hair-regrowth or liver-disease treatment claims.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Medicated oil, powder, extracts and multi-herb preparations. No universal dose established; follow a verified product monograph and practitioner guidance.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Bhṛṅgarāja taila (various regional recipes); check exact ingredients and manufacturing standard.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS

Topical allergy is possible. Safety of prolonged oral use, pregnancy and lactation is insufficiently characterized. Do not use as a substitute for evaluation of hair loss or liver symptoms.

SOURCES

Botanical taxonomic references (Plants of the World Online); published phytochemistry reviews of Eclipta prostrata; selected Ayurvedic nighaṇṭu (edition verification).

Asthi-saṃhāra | Hadjod

English: Veld grape • Hindi: Hadjod • Botanical: Cissus quadrangularis L. • Family: Vitaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE

Asthi-saṃhāra or Hadjod commonly denotes Cissus quadrangularis, a fleshy-stemmed climber. It is traditionally associated with bone and joint care; the name does not establish proven fracture-healing efficacy.

QUICK FACTS

Characteristic four-angled succulent stems. Plant part: stem. Exact rasa-pañcaka and traditional actions vary by reference and require edition-level confirmation.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Check Asthi-saṃhāra and related synonyms in named Ayurvedic nighaṇṭus; do not invent a verse reference.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Polyphenols, triterpenoids and phytosterols reported; extract profiles vary widely and marker standardization is inconsistent.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Used traditionally as supportive care for fractures, joint discomfort and in certain digestive preparations.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

Historical use as an adjunct in musculoskeletal care; immobilization and medical assessment remain essential for fractures.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Small human studies and preclinical work exist, but evidence is not strong enough to replace standard fracture management.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Stem powder and standardized or nonstandardized extracts. No universally validated dose; products are not equivalent.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Regional Hadjod powders and compound formulations; verify specific names and recipes before clinical use.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS

Possible gastrointestinal upset and allergy. Pregnancy, lactation, pediatric and long-term safety data are limited. Suspected fractures require prompt medical evaluation.

SOURCES

Kew Plants of the World Online; peer-reviewed Cissus quadrangularis clinical and phytochemical reviews; Ayurvedic materia medica (verify edition).

Gokṣura | Puncture vine

English: Puncture vine • Hindi: Gokhru • Botanical: Tribulus terrestris L. • Family: Zygophyllaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE

Gokṣura commonly refers to Tribulus terrestris fruit in Ayurvedic practice. Regional “gokhru” may also denote Pedalium murex (large gokhru); authenticate the species and plant part.

QUICK FACTS

Prostrate herb with hard spiny fruits. Part: fruit primarily. Exact classical rasa-pañcaka and karma should be verified in a selected reference.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Gokṣura occurs in classical formulations including Daśamūla and Gokṣurādi preparations; exact composition depends on text and edition.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Steroidal saponins (including protodioscin in some material), flavonoids and other metabolites; amounts differ substantially across origins.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Traditionally used in urinary-tract and related formulations, often as part of multi-herb combinations.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

An established traditional urinary-system ingredient; testosterone-boosting claims are not reliably supported.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Human studies are limited and inconsistent for sexual function and other indications; product heterogeneity restricts conclusions.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Dried fruit powder, decoction and compound products. No universally established dose for all preparations.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Gokṣurādi guggulu (formula-specific); Daśamūla combinations may include Gokṣura as one of ten roots depending on tradition.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS

Reports of liver/kidney injury with some supplements exist; causality and product quality may vary. Avoid in pregnancy; discuss use with a clinician if taking medicines or having kidney disease.

SOURCES

Kew taxonomic records; NIH/NCCIH and peer-reviewed Tribulus reviews; Ayurvedic Formulary of India for named formulas.

Kapikacchu | Velvet bean

English: Velvet bean • Hindi: Kaunch • Botanical: Mucuna pruriens (L.) DC. • Family: Fabaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE

Kapikacchu is Mucuna pruriens, whose seeds naturally contain levodopa (L-DOPA), a pharmacologically active dopamine precursor. Seed preparations are not equivalent to ordinary dietary legumes.

QUICK FACTS

Tropical climbing legume with pods bearing irritating hairs. Plant part: seed in medicinal preparations; raw pod hairs cause severe itching. Species, preparation and L-DOPA content must be identified.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Kapikacchu appears in Ayurvedic materia medica; verify synonyms and named preparations in the selected edition before citing verses.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

L-DOPA (content highly variable), proteins, polyphenols and other seed metabolites.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Used in traditional reproductive-health and neurological formulations; historical indications are not proof of efficacy.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

A botanical source of L-DOPA, but potency variability makes unsupervised dosing hazardous.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Small studies in Parkinson disease exist; evidence is limited and cannot establish equivalent safety, dosing or efficacy to regulated levodopa medication.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Processed seed powder and extracts. Do not self-dose; actual L-DOPA content must be assessed and dosing managed by a qualified clinician.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Kapikacchu-based powders and compound formulations; confirm exact recipe and processing requirements.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS

Can cause nausea, low blood pressure, involuntary movements, psychiatric symptoms and medication interactions. Especially concerning with dopaminergic drugs, MAO inhibitors and some psychiatric medicines. Avoid in pregnancy/lactation unless specialist-directed.

SOURCES

Peer-reviewed Mucuna pruriens/Parkinson disease clinical literature; pharmacognosy sources; named Ayurvedic nighaṇṭu (edition verification).

Candana | Sandalwood

English: Indian sandalwood • Hindi: Chandan • Botanical: Santalum album L. • Family: Santalaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE

Śveta candana generally denotes the fragrant heartwood of Santalum album. Distinguish true Indian sandalwood from red sandalwood (Pterocarpus santalinus), which is botanically unrelated.

QUICK FACTS

Small hemiparasitic tree. Plant part: fragrant heartwood; essential oil is a concentrated, distinct product. Sustainable sourcing and species authentication matter.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Candana is discussed in Ayurvedic nighaṇṭus and aromatic/cooling preparations; verify the chosen edition for exact rasa-pañcaka and indications.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Heartwood oil contains α-santalol and β-santalol among other sesquiterpene alcohols.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Traditional topical cooling and aromatic applications; appears in selected skin and fragrance preparations.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

Fragrance and culturally established topical use; disease-treatment claims need condition-specific evidence.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Laboratory antimicrobial and anti-inflammatory findings do not establish clinical efficacy for most indications.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Heartwood paste, powder, perfumery and topical preparations. No universal medicinal dose; do not ingest essential oil.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Candana-containing oils and pastes; verify recipe and identity of “candana” before use.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS

Skin sensitization or contact dermatitis is possible. Essential oil must be appropriately diluted; avoid ingestion and use caution with children and pregnancy. Prefer legally and sustainably sourced material.

SOURCES

Kew Plants of the World Online; ISO/pharmacognosy descriptions of sandalwood oil; classical nighaṇṭu references (edition verification).

Bābui tulasī | Sweet basil

English: Sweet basil • Botanical: Ocimum basilicum L. • Family: Lamiaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE

Sweet basil is Ocimum basilicum, a culinary herb. It must not be confused with holy basil/tulsi (Ocimum tenuiflorum). The Sanskrit heading is a descriptive trade rendering, not a verified classical synonym.

QUICK FACTS

Aromatic annual herb with many cultivars and chemotypes. Part: leaf/aerial parts. Do not transfer Tulsi rasa-pañcaka or classical indications to sweet basil.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

A direct classical Ayurvedic identity for O. basilicum is not securely established here. Data not established; avoid attributing Tulsi verses to this species.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Essential-oil constituents can include linalool, eugenol, methyl chavicol (estragole) and others depending on chemotype.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Widely used as culinary aromatic and in diverse regional herbal traditions; species-specific classical Ayurvedic indications not established.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

Flavorful culinary herb; nutrition and aroma are better established than medicinal disease claims.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Predominantly laboratory and small human studies; insufficient robust clinical evidence for therapeutic use.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Fresh/dried leaves as food; teas and extracts. Culinary quantities differ from concentrated essential oils; no validated therapeutic dose.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

No reliably verified classical Ayurvedic formulation specifically attributable to O. basilicum in this monograph.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS

Food use is generally tolerated; allergy possible. Avoid self-administering concentrated basil oil, especially in pregnancy or children; estragole content varies.

SOURCES

Kew Plants of the World Online; EMA/public toxicology reviews of estragole; peer-reviewed Ocimum basilicum chemistry reviews.

Spearmint | Pudina species

English: Spearmint • Botanical: Mentha spicata L. • Family: Lamiaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE

Spearmint is Mentha spicata. The common word “pudina” is ambiguous across Mentha species; distinguish spearmint from peppermint (M. × piperita) and field mint (M. arvensis).

QUICK FACTS

Aromatic perennial mint. Leaf and aerial parts are commonly used. Classical Sanskrit identity and rasa-pañcaka are not established for this precise species.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Species-specific classical Sanskrit citations: Data not established. Do not transfer another Mentha species’ references.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Spearmint oil is commonly carvone-rich, with limonene and other monoterpenes; chemotypes vary.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Culinary flavoring and traditional digestive tea in many regions; not a validated treatment for gastrointestinal disease.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

Palatable aromatic leaf for food and tea; therapeutic claims remain uncertain.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Small studies examine hormonal and other outcomes, but evidence is insufficient for standard clinical recommendations.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Leaves, tea and food flavoring. No universal medicinal dose; essential oil is much more concentrated.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

No verified classical Ayurvedic formula specifically requiring Mentha spicata is stated.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS

Allergy or reflux symptoms may occur. Do not ingest concentrated essential oil without specialist supervision; keep oils away from young children. Pregnancy safety of medicinal extracts is uncertain.

SOURCES

Kew taxonomic records; pharmacognosy and essential-oil chemistry reviews of Mentha spicata; clinical literature on spearmint tea.

Peppermint | Hybrid mint

English: Peppermint • Botanical: Mentha × piperita L. • Family: Lamiaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE

Peppermint is a hybrid mint, Mentha × piperita, distinct from spearmint and field mint. Standardized enteric-coated peppermint oil capsules are a different intervention from leaf tea or undiluted essential oil.

QUICK FACTS

Aromatic hybrid perennial. Parts: leaves and essential oil. A verified classical Sanskrit name and species-specific rasa-pañcaka are not established.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Species-specific Ayurvedic classical references: Data not established; do not misattribute generic Pudina descriptions.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Menthol and menthone are prominent in many peppermint oils; composition varies by source and standard.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Traditional use for digestive discomfort and as an aromatic herb; historical use is separate from modern clinical evidence.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

Some enteric-coated peppermint-oil products can improve global symptoms of irritable bowel syndrome (IBS) in the short term.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Clinical trials and guideline reviews support modest short-term IBS symptom relief for certain enteric-coated oil formulations; evidence does not generalize to all teas or oils.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Leaf tea, diluted topical oil, enteric-coated capsules. Use only product-specific labeled directions; no single dose fits all preparations.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Modern enteric-coated peppermint-oil products; no specific classical Ayurvedic formula established for this hybrid.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS

May worsen reflux/heartburn. Essential oil can irritate skin and mucosa; avoid application near infants’ faces. Gallbladder disease and drug interactions warrant professional advice.

SOURCES

NCCIH Peppermint Oil overview; American College of Gastroenterology IBS guideline; EMA peppermint leaf/oil monographs.

Lavaṅga | Clove

English: Clove • Hindi: Laung • Botanical: Syzygium aromaticum (L.) Merr. & L.M.Perry • Family: Myrtaceae

DEFINITION AND SCOPE

Lavaṅga is the dried unopened flower bud of Syzygium aromaticum. The whole spice and concentrated clove essential oil are not interchangeable.

QUICK FACTS

Evergreen tropical tree; harvested aromatic flower buds. Part: dried flower bud. Classical properties and synonyms should be checked in the selected nighaṇṭu.

CLASSICAL REFERENCES

Lavaṅga is recorded in later Ayurvedic materia medica and compound aromatic preparations; verify exact reference and edition before quoting.

KEY ACTIVE CONSTITUENTS

Eugenol is a major component of clove oil, alongside eugenyl acetate and β-caryophyllene.

TRADITIONAL USES (ROGAGHNATĀ)

Culinary spice and traditional oral/dental and digestive aromatic uses.

WHY USE IT? MAIN BENEFITS

Clove/eugenol preparations have a history in dentistry, but tooth pain may indicate infection requiring dental assessment.

MODERN SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

Local anesthetic and antimicrobial effects are documented experimentally; high-quality clinical evidence for many herbal claims is limited.

COMMON FORMS AND DOSE

Whole buds, ground spice and professionally formulated dental preparations. No universal therapeutic dose; do not apply undiluted clove oil to gums.

IMPORTANT FORMULATIONS

Aromatic dental preparations and multi-spice formulations; check the exact standard and concentration.

SAFETY & CAUTIONS

Concentrated clove oil can burn mucosa and cause serious poisoning, especially in children; ingestion can damage the liver. Eugenol may affect bleeding risk. Seek urgent care after significant oil ingestion.

SOURCES

NCCIH and toxicology references on clove oil/eugenol; Kew taxonomy; Ayurvedic nighaṇṭu (edition verification).

Indian Bay Leaf

Cinnamomum tamala (Buch.-Ham.) T.Nees & Eberm.

Part used: Leaves | Family: Lauraceae | Identity note: Distinct from Mediterranean bay leaf (Laurus nobilis).

Definition & scope

A culinary leaf and traditional Ayurvedic aromatic dravya. The profile below concerns Cinnamomum tamala, not Laurus nobilis.

Constituents

Leaves contain volatile oils; reported components vary by chemotype and source. Exact composition is batch-dependent.

Traditional indications

Used in food and traditional preparations as an aromatic digestive adjunct. Evidence for treating specific diseases is limited.

Benefits & evidence

Culinary use is established. Clinical evidence for medicinal claims is insufficient; do not treat traditional use as proof of efficacy.

Forms & dose

Used as a culinary spice or in traditional formulations. A standardized medicinal dose is not established here; follow a qualified clinician's advice.

Formulations

May occur in spice mixtures and classical compound preparations; formulation-specific references should be checked before prescribing.

Safety

Avoid concentrated essential oil ingestion. Culinary amounts are generally different from medicinal-dose exposure. Allergy or irritation is possible.

Sources

Botanical identity: Kew Plants of the World Online (Cinnamomum tamala); traditional context: standard Ayurvedic materia medica. Specific formulation and dose references require verification.

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Verify identity, preparation, dose, interactions, and source quality with a qualified professional.

Garlic

Allium sativum L.

Part used: Bulb | Family: Amaryllidaceae (formerly Alliaceae in some references).

Definition & scope

A widely used food plant with a history of traditional medicinal use. Food use and concentrated supplements should be considered separately.

Constituents

Sulfur-containing compounds, including alliin and allicin formed when garlic is crushed; composition depends on preparation.

Traditional indications

Used traditionally as a pungent food and in varied folk and traditional practices. Specific Ayurvedic indications vary across texts and preparations.

Benefits & evidence

Some clinical evidence suggests modest effects on blood pressure or lipids for certain preparations, but results are variable and product-specific.

Forms & dose

Fresh bulb, cooked garlic, powders, and extracts differ substantially. No universal medicinal dose is given here.

Formulations

Used in food and some traditional compound preparations. Confirm the exact classical formulation before attributing a textual indication.

Safety

May cause gastrointestinal upset or allergy. Concentrated supplements can increase bleeding risk and interact with anticoagulants/antiplatelet medicines; seek advice before surgery.

Sources

NCCIH, Garlic: Usefulness and Safety; botanical identity: Kew Plants of the World Online (Allium sativum).

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Verify identity, preparation, dose, interactions, and source quality with a qualified professional.

Ajwain (Carom)

Trachyspermum ammi (L.) Sprague

Part used: Fruits (commonly called seeds) | Family: Apiaceae.

Definition & scope
An aromatic culinary spice used in South Asian food and traditional digestive preparations.

Constituents
Volatile oil commonly rich in thymol; levels vary with origin and processing.

Traditional indications
Traditionally used for gas, indigestion, and abdominal discomfort. These uses are not a substitute for evaluating persistent or severe symptoms.

Benefits & evidence
Laboratory and traditional evidence exists, but robust human clinical evidence for treating specific conditions is limited.

Forms & dose
Culinary fruit, infusions, and traditional preparations. A generally applicable medicinal dose is not established in this monograph.

Formulations
Appears in household and compound digestive preparations; exact ingredients and proportions vary.

Safety
Concentrated oils may irritate tissues and can be toxic if swallowed inappropriately. Avoid medicinal quantities during pregnancy unless advised by a qualified clinician.

Sources
Botanical identity: Kew Plants of the World Online (Trachyspermum ammi); evidence and safety statements should be checked against current clinical references.

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Verify identity, preparation, dose, interactions, and source quality with a qualified professional.

Tamarind

Tamarindus indica L.

Part used: Fruit pulp; other parts have separate traditional uses | Family: Fabaceae.

Definition & scope

A tropical tree whose sour fruit pulp is widely used as food. Medicinal claims about bark, leaves, seeds, or extracts should not be generalized from food use.

Constituents

Fruit pulp contains organic acids, sugars, and polyphenolic compounds; composition varies with ripeness and processing.

Traditional indications

Used as a food and traditional digestive ingredient. Specific therapeutic use depends on plant part and preparation.

Benefits & evidence

Nutritional and laboratory findings exist, but evidence for many disease-treatment claims is insufficient.

Forms & dose

Food pulp, drinks, and culinary preparations. No universal medicinal dose is established here.

Formulations

Used in foods, chutneys, and some traditional preparations; verify the exact plant part and recipe.

Safety

May cause gastrointestinal symptoms in large amounts. Tamarind products may affect medication handling in some circumstances; ask a pharmacist if taking regular medicines.

Sources

Botanical identity: Kew Plants of the World Online (Tamarindus indica); nutrition and safety details depend on preparation.

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Verify identity, preparation, dose, interactions, and source quality with a qualified professional.

Ashoka

Saraca asoca (Roxb.) Willd.

Part used: Bark (traditional use) | Family: Fabaceae | Identity caution: trade-name substitution can occur.

Definition & scope

An important tree in Ayurvedic materia medica. Correct botanical identification is essential because trade materials may be substituted or adulterated.

Constituents

Bark contains diverse polyphenolic and other compounds; reported profiles depend on authentication and extraction.

Traditional indications

Classically associated with women's reproductive health, including traditional formulations for menstrual complaints. This does not establish efficacy for all gynecologic conditions.

Benefits & evidence

Traditional use is well known, but high-quality clinical evidence for specific indications remains limited.

Forms & dose

Authenticated bark and compound formulations are used traditionally. No self-prescription dose is provided; menstrual or abnormal bleeding requires clinical assessment.

Formulations

Ashokarishta and other named preparations are associated with Saraca asoca; verify product ingredients and quality.

Safety

Do not use to delay evaluation of heavy bleeding, pregnancy-related symptoms, severe pelvic pain, or unexplained bleeding. Seek qualified medical advice, especially during pregnancy or while taking medicines.

Sources

Botanical identity: Kew Plants of the World Online (Saraca asoca); traditional formulation details should be verified against authoritative Ayurvedic formularies.

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Verify identity, preparation, dose, interactions, and source quality with a qualified professional.

Indian Sarsaparilla

Hemidesmus indicus (L.) R.Br. ex Schult.

Part used: Root | Family: Apocynaceae.

Definition & scope
A medicinal plant traditionally known as Anantamul or Sariva in many Indian materia medica contexts. Names can refer to more than one species, so verify identity.

Constituents
Root contains aromatic and other phytochemicals; chemical composition varies with provenance and processing.

Traditional indications
Traditionally used in preparations described as cooling or supportive for skin and urinary complaints. These are traditional categories, not proven clinical outcomes.

Benefits & evidence
Preclinical research exists; reliable clinical evidence for specific disease claims is limited.

Forms & dose
Root decoctions and compound preparations are described traditionally. A standardized dose is not established here.

Formulations
May appear in Sariva-containing compound preparations. Check the species and plant part listed on the product label.

Safety
Safety data for concentrated extracts are limited. Avoid unsupervised medicinal use during pregnancy, breastfeeding, or with significant chronic illness.

Sources
Botanical identity: Kew Plants of the World Online (Hemidesmus indicus); traditional uses: standard Ayurvedic materia medica, with formulation-level claims requiring verification.

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Verify identity, preparation, dose, interactions, and source quality with a qualified professional.

Chitraka

Plumbago zeylanica L.

CAUTION — IRRITANT / TOXICITY RISK
Only under supervision of a qualified Vaidya, in processed form. No self-use dose.

Part used: Root (traditional use) | Family: Plumbaginaceae | CAUTION: Irritant plant; processing and supervision are essential.

Definition & scope

A pungent Ayurvedic drug traditionally used in processed formulations. The plant contains irritant compounds and should not be handled or consumed casually.

Constituents

Plumbagin and related naphthoquinones have been reported; these compounds contribute to biological activity and toxicity.

Traditional indications

Classically described in digestive and appetite-related formulations. Traditional indication does not imply that raw root is safe or effective.

Benefits & evidence

Most evidence is preclinical. Robust clinical evidence and a universally safe dose are not established.

Forms & dose

No self-use dose is provided. Do not ingest raw root, home-made extracts, or unverified products.

Formulations

Used in certain classical formulations after prescribed processing. Confirm the exact preparation and authoritative monograph.

Safety

May cause severe skin and mucosal irritation and gastrointestinal toxicity. Avoid during pregnancy; do not self-administer. If swallowed or significant exposure occurs, contact emergency/poison services promptly.

Sources

Botanical identity: Kew Plants of the World Online (Plumbago zeylanica); safety concerns supported by phytochemical/toxicology literature. Classical processing details must be verified in a recognized formulary.

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Verify identity, preparation, dose, interactions, and source quality with a qualified professional.

Vasaka (Malabar Nut)

Justicia adhatoda L. (syn. Adhatoda vasica Nees)

Part used: Leaves and other parts in specific preparations | Family: Acanthaceae.

Definition & scope

A medicinal shrub traditionally used in respiratory formulations. The plant part and preparation matter; it is not a replacement for prescribed asthma or infection treatment.

Constituents

Quinazoline alkaloids including vasicine and vasicinone are reported; concentration varies by part and preparation.

Traditional indications

Traditionally used in cough and respiratory preparations. Persistent breathlessness, chest pain, high fever, or coughing blood needs urgent medical evaluation.

Benefits & evidence

Pharmacological and traditional evidence exists, but strong clinical evidence for many specific claims is limited.

Forms & dose

Leaf-based preparations and compound products are used traditionally. No universal dose is provided; pregnancy is a key precaution.

Formulations

Appears in traditional respiratory formulations; verify composition and quality of the marketed product.

Safety

Vasicine may have uterotonic effects; avoid medicinal use during pregnancy unless specifically directed by a qualified clinician. Check interactions and do not stop prescribed respiratory medicines.

Sources

Botanical identity: Kew Plants of the World Online (Justicia adhatoda); safety and pharmacology: current pharmacognosy/toxicology references.

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Verify identity, preparation, dose, interactions, and source quality with a qualified professional.

Henna

Lawsonia inermis L.

Part used: Leaves (dye and traditional topical use) | Family: Lythraceae.

Definition & scope

A plant used for body-art dye and traditional topical applications. Natural henna is different from products adulterated with para-phenylenediamine (PPD).

Constituents

Leaves contain lawsone, a naphthoquinone pigment. Product composition depends on preparation and additives.

Traditional indications

Used chiefly as a dye and in traditional topical practices. Evidence for treating skin or scalp disease is limited.

Benefits & evidence

Hair/body dye use is established; medicinal claims are not well supported by high-quality clinical studies.

Forms & dose

Topical leaf paste and commercial products. No oral medicinal dose is recommended in this monograph.

Formulations

Used in traditional cosmetic preparations. Review ingredient lists and avoid unknown “black henna” products.

Safety

PPD-containing black henna can cause severe allergic reactions and scarring. Henna should not be applied to infants, especially those with G6PD deficiency, because lawsone exposure may trigger hemolysis. Avoid ingestion.

Sources

Botanical identity: Kew Plants of the World Online (Lawsonia inermis); FDA consumer information on temporary tattoos/black henna and PPD.

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Verify identity, preparation, dose, interactions, and source quality with a qualified professional.

Bhumyamalaki

Phyllanthus amarus Schumach. & Thonn. (identity can vary by region)

Part used: Whole plant | Family: Phyllanthaceae | Identity caution: Common name may be applied to related Phyllanthus species.

Definition & scope

A small herb used in Ayurveda and other traditional systems. Common names may refer to related species; botanical authentication is important.

Constituents

Reported lignans, flavonoids, and tannins vary by species and extraction method.

Traditional indications

Traditionally used in preparations related to liver and urinary health. It must not replace evaluation or treatment of hepatitis or other liver disease.

Benefits & evidence

Preclinical studies and small human studies exist, but clinical evidence is insufficient to establish reliable disease-treatment benefits.

Forms & dose

Whole-plant preparations and extracts are used traditionally. No standardized dose is given because identity and preparations vary.

Formulations

Included in some traditional liver-support formulations; verify the species and product quality.

Safety

May affect blood glucose or blood pressure and could interact with medicines. People with liver disease, pregnancy, or ongoing prescriptions should consult a qualified clinician before use.

Sources

Botanical identity: Kew Plants of the World Online (Phyllanthus amarus); clinical evidence should be reviewed from current systematic and clinical sources.

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Verify identity, preparation, dose, interactions, and source quality with a qualified professional.

Chirayata

Swertia chirayita (Roxb.) H.Karst.

Part used: Whole plant | Family: Gentianaceae.

Definition & scope

Traditionally used as a bitter herb in digestive and fever-related preparations. Botanical identity and quality are important because bitter herbs may be substituted.

Constituents

Secoiridoid bitter compounds, including amarogentin and swertiamarin, are reported; levels vary with species, origin, and processing.

Traditional indications

Traditional use is not proof of clinical benefit. Reliable human evidence for specific disease treatment is limited; persistent fever needs medical assessment.

Benefits & evidence

Traditional use is not proof of clinical benefit. Reliable human evidence for specific disease treatment is limited; persistent fever needs medical assessment.

Forms & dose

Whole-plant preparations and compound products are described in traditional practice. A standardized dose is not supplied here.

Formulations

Traditional formulations vary by region, plant identity, and processing. Confirm the exact ingredients and authoritative reference before prescribing.

Safety

May cause gastrointestinal upset and could affect glucose regulation or interact with medicines. Avoid unsupervised use in pregnancy, breastfeeding, or significant illness.

Sources

Botanical identity: Kew Plants of the World Online (Swertia chirayita); consult current pharmacopoeial and clinical references for quality and safety.

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Consult a qualified professional for individual advice.

Pashanabheda

Bergenia ligulata (Wall.) Engl. (name may be used for other taxa regionally)

Part used: Rhizome/root | Family: Saxifragaceae | Identity caution: Common name varies by region.

Definition & scope

An Ayurvedic name associated with plants used in traditional urinary and calculus-related preparations. Because the name is applied to more than one species, authenticated botanical identity is essential.

Constituents

Reported constituents include bergenin and other phenolic compounds; content depends on the authenticated species and extract.

Traditional indications

Traditionally used in urinary formulations, including those associated with stones. It must not replace assessment of severe flank pain, fever, blood in urine, or urinary obstruction.

Benefits & evidence

Laboratory and traditional data exist, but strong clinical evidence for dissolving or preventing stones is insufficient.

Forms & dose

Traditional rhizome preparations and compound products exist. No universal medicinal dose is established in this monograph.

Formulations

Traditional formulations vary by region, plant identity, and processing. Confirm the exact ingredients and authoritative reference before prescribing.

Safety

Seek urgent care for fever with urinary pain, inability to urinate, or severe pain. Use caution with kidney disease and medicines; avoid self-treatment of suspected stones.

Sources

Botanical identity: Kew Plants of the World Online (Bergenia ligulata); clinical claims require review of current urology guidance and controlled studies.

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Consult a qualified professional for individual advice.

Jatamansi

Nardostachys jatamansi (D.Don) DC.

Part used: Rhizome/root | Family: Caprifoliaceae (classification varies in references).

Definition & scope

A high-altitude aromatic plant used in traditional Ayurvedic preparations. It is vulnerable to overharvesting; sustainable sourcing and correct identity matter.

Constituents

Essential-oil constituents and sesquiterpenes have been reported; composition varies with source and processing.

Traditional indications

Traditionally used in calming and sleep-related preparations. Persistent insomnia, anxiety, or mood symptoms merit appropriate clinical evaluation.

Benefits & evidence

Evidence for specific clinical benefits remains limited; traditional use should not be treated as proof of effectiveness.

Forms & dose

Rhizome-based traditional preparations and extracts are available. A standardized dose is not given because products and evidence vary.

Formulations

Traditional formulations vary by region, plant identity, and processing. Confirm the exact ingredients and authoritative reference before prescribing.

Safety

May cause sedation and could interact with sedatives or other medicines. Avoid during pregnancy or breastfeeding unless specifically advised by a qualified clinician.

Sources

Botanical identity: Kew Plants of the World Online (Nardostachys jatamansi); sustainability and safety should be checked against current conservation and clinical sources.

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Consult a qualified professional for individual advice.

Tagara

Valeriana jatamansi Jones (often called Indian valerian; names vary)

Part used: Root/rhizome | Family: Caprifoliaceae.

Definition & scope

An aromatic plant used in traditional preparations associated with relaxation and sleep. Do not confuse it automatically with European Valeriana officinalis.

Constituents

Valepotriates, volatile constituents, and other compounds have been reported in valerian-related taxa; chemistry varies by species and preparation.

Traditional indications

Traditionally used in sleep and calming preparations. Sleep disturbance may have medical, medication-related, or psychological causes that need assessment.

Benefits & evidence

Clinical evidence for this species and specific preparations is limited; data for other Valeriana species cannot be assumed to apply directly.

Forms & dose

Traditional root preparations and commercial products. No standardized dose is provided here.

Formulations

Traditional formulations vary by region, plant identity, and processing. Confirm the exact ingredients and authoritative reference before prescribing.

Safety

May cause drowsiness; avoid combining with alcohol, sedatives, or other products that impair alertness. Do not drive if drowsy; consult a clinician during pregnancy or while taking medicines.

Sources

Botanical identity: Kew Plants of the World Online (Valeriana jatamansi); clinical evidence must be species- and product-specific.

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Consult a qualified professional for individual advice.

Manjistha

Rubia cordifolia L.

Part used: Root/rhizome | Family: Rubiaceae.

Definition & scope

A traditional Ayurvedic plant used in compound preparations, commonly discussed in relation to skin and traditional blood-purification concepts. These concepts are not equivalent to a modern diagnosis.

Constituents

Anthraquinones and other compounds are reported; constituent profiles depend on species, plant part, and extraction.

Traditional indications

Traditional use includes skin-related and other compound formulations. New, spreading, painful, or infected skin lesions need medical assessment.

Benefits & evidence

Preclinical studies exist, but clinical evidence for many claimed disease benefits is limited.

Forms & dose

Root-based traditional preparations and compound products. No universal dose is supplied here.

Formulations

Traditional formulations vary by region, plant identity, and processing. Confirm the exact ingredients and authoritative reference before prescribing.

Safety

Safety of concentrated extracts is not well established. Avoid unsupervised medicinal use during pregnancy or breastfeeding; check interactions with a qualified clinician.

Sources

Botanical identity: Kew Plants of the World Online (Rubia cordifolia); traditional uses and product safety require current formulary review.

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Consult a qualified professional for individual advice.

Nagarmotha

Cyperus rotundus L.

Part used: Rhizome/tuber | Family: Cyperaceae.

Definition & scope

A common aromatic sedge used in Ayurvedic and other traditional systems. Common names and regional substitutes should be checked against botanical identity.

Constituents

Essential oils and sesquiterpenes, including cyperene-related compounds, have been reported; content varies.

Traditional indications

Traditionally used in digestive and other compound preparations. These uses do not establish treatment efficacy for chronic gastrointestinal symptoms.

Benefits & evidence

Much evidence is preclinical or traditional; robust clinical evidence is limited.

Forms & dose

Rhizome-based powders, decoctions, and compound formulations are described. No standardized dose is provided.

Formulations

Traditional formulations vary by region, plant identity, and processing. Confirm the exact ingredients and authoritative reference before prescribing.

Safety

Human safety data for concentrated preparations are limited. Seek advice during pregnancy, breastfeeding, or if taking regular medicines.

Sources

Botanical identity: Kew Plants of the World Online (Cyperus rotundus); safety and efficacy require current clinical references.

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Consult a qualified professional for individual advice.

Vetiver (Ushira)

Chrysopogon zizanioides (L.) Roberty (syn. Vetiveria zizanioides)

Part used: Roots | Family: Poaceae.

Definition & scope

An aromatic grass whose roots are used for fragrance and in traditional cooling preparations. Cosmetic/fragrance use differs from ingestion as medicine.

Constituents

Vetiver root oil contains complex sesquiterpenes; composition depends on origin and distillation.

Traditional indications

Traditional use includes aromatic, cooling, and compound preparations. Claims about treating fever or disease are not established by scent or traditional use alone.

Benefits & evidence

Clinical evidence for specific medicinal outcomes is insufficient.

Forms & dose

Root infusions and aromatic products exist; do not ingest essential oil unless a qualified professional specifically directs a regulated product.

Formulations

Traditional formulations vary by region, plant identity, and processing. Confirm the exact ingredients and authoritative reference before prescribing.

Safety

Essential oils can irritate skin and may be harmful if swallowed. Dilute topical products appropriately and keep concentrated oils away from children.

Sources

Botanical identity: Kew Plants of the World Online (Chrysopogon zizanioides); fragrance safety should follow current cosmetic and essential-oil guidance.

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Consult a qualified professional for individual advice.

Vidanga

Embelia ribes Burm.f.

Part used: Fruit | Family: Primulaceae (classification varies across references).

Definition & scope

A traditional Ayurvedic fruit used in some digestive and anthelmintic formulations. Correct identification and product quality are important.

Constituents

Embelin is a characteristic reported constituent; amount varies with plant material and extraction.

Traditional indications

Traditional use includes preparations for intestinal parasites. Suspected parasitic infection requires proper diagnosis and evidence-based treatment.

Benefits & evidence

Preclinical and traditional evidence exists, but high-quality human evidence is limited.

Forms & dose

Fruit-based traditional formulations are described. No self-treatment dose is provided; do not use it instead of prescribed antiparasitic treatment.

Formulations

Traditional formulations vary by region, plant identity, and processing. Confirm the exact ingredients and authoritative reference before prescribing.

Safety

Safety data are limited; possible gastrointestinal effects and interactions should be considered. Avoid medicinal use during pregnancy without professional guidance.

Sources

Botanical identity: Kew Plants of the World Online (Embelia ribes); verify clinical and safety claims in current pharmacopoeial sources.

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Consult a qualified professional for individual advice.

Amaltas

Cassia fistula L.

Part used: Fruit pulp in traditional laxative preparations | Family: Fabaceae.

Definition & scope

A flowering tree whose fruit pulp has been used traditionally as a laxative. Laxative use requires attention to cause, duration, and hydration.

Constituents

Fruit pulp contains anthraquinone-related compounds and other constituents; concentrations vary by maturity and preparation.

Traditional indications

Traditional use includes relief of occasional constipation. Persistent constipation, severe abdominal pain, vomiting, or blood in stool requires medical evaluation.

Benefits & evidence

Evidence for specific medicinal products is limited; laxative effects do not establish broader therapeutic benefits.

Forms & dose

Fruit-pulp preparations are described in traditional practice. No standardized dose is supplied; avoid repeated self-treatment.

Formulations

Traditional formulations vary by region, plant identity, and processing. Confirm the exact ingredients and authoritative reference before prescribing.

Safety

May cause cramping or diarrhea and may disturb fluid/electrolyte balance if overused. Seek advice for children, pregnancy, older adults, or people with kidney/heart disease.

Sources

Botanical identity: Kew Plants of the World Online (Cassia fistula); laxative safety should follow current clinical guidance.

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Consult a qualified professional for individual advice.

Senna

Senna alexandrina Mill. (syn. Cassia angustifolia Vahl in some sources)

Part used: Leaflets and pods | Family: Fabaceae | CAUTION: Stimulant laxative.

Definition & scope

A medicinal plant used in regulated products for short-term relief of occasional constipation. It should not be used as a routine weight-loss method or for prolonged unsupervised bowel management.

Constituents

Sennosides are the main stimulant-laxative constituents in standardized products.

Traditional indications

Short-term constipation relief is an established use for appropriate senna products. Persistent constipation may signal an underlying condition.

Benefits & evidence

Evidence supports short-term laxative action for specific standardized products; it does not support detoxification or weight-loss claims.

Forms & dose

Use only according to the specific licensed product label or clinician/pharmacist advice. No generalized dose is provided because preparations and regulations differ.

Formulations

Traditional formulations vary by region, plant identity, and processing. Confirm the exact ingredients and authoritative reference before prescribing.

Safety

May cause abdominal cramps, diarrhea, dehydration, and electrolyte imbalance if overused. Avoid prolonged use and seek advice for pregnancy, bowel obstruction symptoms, or use of diuretics/heart medicines.

Sources

National health service or regulator guidance for senna products; botanical identity: Kew Plants of the World Online (Senna alexandrina).

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Consult a qualified professional for individual advice.

Wild Turmeric

Curcuma aromatica Salisb.

Part used: Rhizome | Family: Zingiberaceae | Identity note: Distinct from culinary turmeric, Curcuma longa.

Definition & scope

An aromatic Curcuma species used in some traditional and cosmetic preparations. Common names can be confused with Curcuma longa; verify the botanical identity.

Constituents

Curcuminoids and volatile compounds have been reported, with composition differing from Curcuma longa and varying by source.

Traditional indications

Traditional and cosmetic use is documented, but reliable clinical evidence for treating disease is limited.

Benefits & evidence

Traditional and cosmetic use is documented, but reliable clinical evidence for treating disease is limited.

Forms & dose

Topical and traditional preparations are described. No standardized oral medicinal dose is provided.

Formulations

Formulation details and classical processing must be verified in authoritative references. No home processing instructions are provided for toxic or irritant materials.

Safety

May cause skin irritation or allergy. Avoid ingesting unverified products and seek advice before medicinal use during pregnancy or while taking medicines.

Sources

Botanical identity: Kew Plants of the World Online (Curcuma aromatica); clinical evidence and safety claims require species-specific review.

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Seek professional advice; suspected poisoning is an emergency.

Zedoary

Curcuma zedoaria (Christm.) Roscoe

Part used: Rhizome | Family: Zingiberaceae.

Definition & scope

A rhizomatous plant used in some traditional systems. It is not interchangeable with Curcuma longa or Curcuma aromatica.

Constituents

Volatile oils and sesquiterpenes are reported; composition depends on plant material and processing.

Traditional indications

Traditionally used in digestive and other compound preparations. Such use does not establish efficacy for a specific disease.

Benefits & evidence

Most evidence is traditional or preclinical; robust clinical evidence is limited.

Forms & dose

Traditional rhizome preparations exist. A universal medicinal dose is not established here.

Formulations

Formulation details and classical processing must be verified in authoritative references. No home processing instructions are provided for toxic or irritant materials.

Safety

Concentrated products may cause adverse effects and interactions; avoid unsupervised medicinal use during pregnancy, breastfeeding, or significant illness.

Sources

Botanical identity: Kew Plants of the World Online (Curcuma zedoaria); current pharmacopoeial and clinical references should guide any therapeutic use.

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Seek professional advice; suspected poisoning is an emergency.

Mango Ginger

Curcuma amada Roxb.

Part used: Rhizome | Family: Zingiberaceae.

Definition & scope

A rhizome with a mango-like aroma used as a food and traditional ingredient. Botanical identity should be confirmed because common names overlap.

Constituents

Volatile oils and phenolic constituents are reported; profile varies with provenance and preparation.

Traditional indications

Used traditionally as a food and in some digestive preparations. Specific medicinal benefits are not established by culinary use alone.

Benefits & evidence

Human clinical evidence for specific therapeutic effects is limited.

Forms & dose

Food preparations and traditional rhizome products. No standardized medicinal dose is provided.

Formulations

Formulation details and classical processing must be verified in authoritative references. No home processing instructions are provided for toxic or irritant materials.

Safety

Food use differs from concentrated extracts. Stop use if allergy or gastrointestinal irritation occurs; consult a clinician for medicinal use with chronic conditions or medications.

Sources

Botanical identity: Kew Plants of the World Online (Curcuma amada); clinical claims require reliable species-specific studies.

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Seek professional advice; suspected poisoning is an emergency.

Langali

Gloriosa superba L.

TOXIC / HIGH-RISK MATERIAL — NO SELF-USE
Only under supervision of a qualified Vaidya, in processed form. Do not use raw material or home-made preparations.

Part used: Historically tuber/root in traditional systems | Family: Colchicaceae | TOXIC — DO NOT SELF-USE.

Definition & scope

A highly toxic plant containing colchicine-related alkaloids. Traditional mentions do not make raw or home-processed material safe.

Constituents

Colchicine and related toxic alkaloids are reported; concentrations can vary and poisoning can be life-threatening.

Traditional indications

Historical/classical references may describe processed use, but this monograph does not recommend therapeutic use. There is no safe home-use indication.

Benefits & evidence

Not suitable for self-treatment. Toxicity risk outweighs any unsupervised use; do not infer safety from traditional processing claims.

Forms & dose

No self-use dose. Only under supervision of a qualified Vaidya, in processed form. Do not collect, prepare, or ingest it yourself.

Formulations

Classical processing and indication details require verification from authoritative texts; no home formulation is provided.

Safety

Can cause severe vomiting, diarrhea, organ failure, bone-marrow suppression, and death. If exposure or ingestion occurs, seek emergency medical care immediately; do not induce vomiting.

Sources

Botanical identity: Kew Plants of the World Online (Gloriosa superba); toxicology literature on colchicine poisoning. Traditional processing details require authoritative formulary verification.

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Seek professional advice; suspected poisoning is an emergency.

Vatsanabha

Aconitum chasmanthum Stapf ex Holmes (name and traded species may vary)

TOXIC / HIGH-RISK MATERIAL — NO SELF-USE
Only under supervision of a qualified Vaidya, in processed form. Do not use raw material or home-made preparations.

Part used: Processed root in classical contexts | Family: Ranunculaceae | TOXIC / SHODHANA REQUIRED.

Definition & scope

Vatsanabha is a high-risk aconite drug name in Ayurvedic literature. Traded species and adulteration can vary; identity and processing cannot be assumed.

Constituents

Aconitum species may contain highly toxic aconitine-type alkaloids that affect cardiac and nervous systems.

Traditional indications

Classical Visha-category material with narrowly described processed use in some formulations. It is not appropriate for self-treatment.

Benefits & evidence

Reliable clinical evidence for many claimed uses is limited, while severe poisoning risk is well documented.

Forms & dose

No self-use dose. Only under supervision of a qualified Vaidya, in processed form. Never use raw root or homemade preparations.

Formulations

Any classical formulation requires authenticated material, validated shodhana, and qualified oversight; no preparation instructions are provided here.

Safety

May cause tingling, weakness, vomiting, dangerous arrhythmias, low blood pressure, and death. Suspected exposure is an emergency; seek immediate medical care and do not induce vomiting.

Sources

Botanical identity and taxonomy: Kew Plants of the World Online (Aconitum taxa); toxicology references on aconite poisoning. Exact classical classification/processing must be verified in authoritative Ayurvedic texts.

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Seek professional advice; suspected poisoning is an emergency.

Jayapala

Croton tiglium L.

TOXIC / HIGH-RISK MATERIAL — NO SELF-USE
Only under supervision of a qualified Vaidya, in processed form. Do not use raw material or home-made preparations.

Part used: Seeds historically used in processed preparations | Family: Euphorbiaceae | TOXIC / SHODHANA REQUIRED.

Definition & scope

A toxic seed drug described in some traditional materia medica. Raw seeds and seed oil are dangerous and must not be used at home.

Constituents

Croton oil contains potent irritant phorbol esters and related compounds; seed material can cause severe gastrointestinal injury.

Traditional indications

Historical/classical use as a strong purgative is not a recommendation. Safer evidence-based options exist for constipation.

Benefits & evidence

Do not self-use. The risk of severe toxicity makes unsupervised use inappropriate.

Forms & dose

No self-use dose. Only under supervision of a qualified Vaidya, in processed form. Do not ingest raw seeds or oil.

Formulations

Classical processing details require authoritative verification; no home preparation or dosing instructions are provided.

Safety

Can cause intense vomiting, diarrhea, dehydration, shock, and organ injury. If swallowed or exposed, seek emergency/poison care immediately; do not induce vomiting.

Sources

Botanical identity: Kew Plants of the World Online (Croton tiglium); toxicology references on croton oil and phorbol esters.

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Seek professional advice; suspected poisoning is an emergency.

Bhallataka

Semecarpus anacardium L.f.

TOXIC / HIGH-RISK MATERIAL — NO SELF-USE
Only under supervision of a qualified Vaidya, in processed form. Do not use raw material or home-made preparations.

Part used: Fruit/nut-like pericarp in processed classical preparations | Family: Anacardiaceae | CAUTION: Strong irritant.

Definition & scope

A traditional medicinal plant requiring careful processing and expert oversight. Raw material can cause severe skin and mucosal irritation.

Constituents

Phenolic lipids including bhilawanols and related compounds are reported; these contribute to irritant potential.

Traditional indications

Classical use is described in processed compound preparations, but claims should be tied to a verified formulation and indication.

Benefits & evidence

Clinical evidence is limited and does not justify self-treatment with raw material.

Forms & dose

No self-use dose. Only under supervision of a qualified Vaidya, in processed form. Avoid handling raw material.

Formulations

Processing and formulation details must be verified from authoritative texts; no home processing instructions are provided.

Safety

Can cause severe contact dermatitis, blistering, and mucosal injury. Avoid during pregnancy unless a qualified specialist specifically advises otherwise. If exposure causes significant burns or ingestion, seek urgent medical care.

Sources

Botanical identity: Kew Plants of the World Online (Semecarpus anacardium); toxicology/dermatology references on irritant phenolic lipids.

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Seek professional advice; suspected poisoning is an emergency.

Castor

Ricinus communis L.

Part used: Castor oil from seeds; other seed material is hazardous | Family: Euphorbiaceae.

Definition & scope

Castor oil has a regulated history as a stimulant laxative in some settings. Whole castor beans are dangerous because they contain ricin.

Constituents

Castor oil is rich in ricinoleic acid; ricin is a potent toxin present in seeds but is not expected in properly manufactured refined castor oil.

Traditional indications

Castor oil may be used for short-term constipation only when appropriate and according to professional or product-label guidance. It is not a general detox or labor-induction remedy.

Benefits & evidence

Evidence supports a laxative effect for certain preparations; many other traditional claims are not established.

Forms & dose

Use only an appropriately manufactured product and follow its label or pharmacist advice. No generalized dose is given here.

Formulations

Formulation details and classical processing must be verified in authoritative references. No home processing instructions are provided for toxic or irritant materials.

Safety

May cause cramping, diarrhea, and dehydration. Avoid during pregnancy unless specifically directed by a clinician. Never ingest crushed seeds or homemade seed preparations.

Sources

Botanical identity: Kew Plants of the World Online (Ricinus communis); poison-control and clinical references on ricin and castor oil.

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Seek professional advice; suspected poisoning is an emergency.

Dhatura

Datura metel L. / Datura stramonium L. (species and names vary)

TOXIC / HIGH-RISK MATERIAL — NO SELF-USE
Only under supervision of a qualified Vaidya, in processed form. Do not use raw material or home-made preparations.

Part used: Various parts in historical/classical contexts | Family: Solanaceae | TOXIC — DO NOT SELF-USE.

Definition & scope

Datura species contain potent tropane alkaloids and can cause life-threatening anticholinergic poisoning. This entry is for identification and safety awareness only.

Constituents

Atropine, scopolamine, and related tropane alkaloids may occur; concentrations are unpredictable across plant parts and species.

Traditional indications

Historical uses do not justify self-treatment. Do not smoke, ingest, or prepare Datura as a home remedy.

Benefits & evidence

Therapeutic claims do not outweigh serious poisoning risk. It should never be self-administered.

Forms & dose

No self-use dose. Do not ingest or apply homemade preparations. Any claimed classical processing requires authoritative verification and expert oversight.

Formulations

No home formulation is provided. Avoid contact with plant material, especially seeds and leaves, and keep away from children and animals.

Safety

May cause dry mouth, dilated pupils, overheating, rapid heartbeat, confusion, hallucinations, seizures, coma, or death. If exposure occurs, seek emergency care immediately; do not induce vomiting.

Sources

Botanical identity: Kew Plants of the World Online (Datura species); poison-control and clinical toxicology references on tropane alkaloid poisoning.

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Seek professional advice; suspected poisoning is an emergency.

Gunja

Abrus precatorius L.

TOXIC / HIGH-RISK MATERIAL — NO SELF-USE
Only under supervision of a qualified Vaidya, in processed form. Do not use raw material or home-made preparations.

Part used: Seeds historically described after processing | Family: Fabaceae | TOXIC — DO NOT SELF-USE.

Definition & scope

An ornamental/climbing plant whose brightly colored seeds are highly poisonous if chewed or damaged. Traditional references do not make raw seeds safe.

Constituents

Abrin, a potent ribosome-inactivating toxin, is present in seeds; risk depends on seed damage and exposure route.

Traditional indications

Historical/classical use in processed forms is not a recommendation for self-treatment. This profile prioritizes toxicity prevention.

Benefits & evidence

Human evidence does not support unsupervised medicinal use; severe poisoning risk is established.

Forms & dose

No self-use dose. Do not chew, swallow, powder, or process seeds at home. Only under supervision of a qualified Vaidya, in processed form, where an authoritative indication is verified.

Formulations

No home preparation instructions. Keep seeds away from children and pets; do not use in homemade cosmetics or medicines.

Safety

Chewed seeds can cause severe vomiting, diarrhea, dehydration, and organ injury; symptoms may be delayed. Suspected ingestion needs immediate emergency/poison advice. Do not induce vomiting.

Sources

Botanical identity: Kew Plants of the World Online (Abrus precatorius); toxicology references on abrin poisoning.

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Seek professional advice; suspected poisoning is an emergency.

Arka (Calotropis)

Calotropis gigantea (L.) Dryand. / Calotropis procera (Aiton) W.T.Aiton

TOXIC / HIGH-RISK MATERIAL — NO SELF-USE
Only under supervision of a qualified Vaidya, in processed form where applicable. Never ingest raw material or homemade preparations.

Part used in traditional sources: varies | Family: Apocynaceae | TOXIC — DO NOT SELF-USE.

Definition & scope

Arka is a traditional plant name often associated with Calotropis species. Latex and other parts are irritant and potentially poisonous; species identity may vary.

Constituents

Latex contains irritant proteolytic enzymes and cardenolide-type compounds; composition differs between species and plant parts.

Traditional indications

Historical/classical references describe limited processed uses, but this monograph does not recommend home treatment with Arka.

Benefits & evidence

Clinical evidence for many claims is limited, while toxic and irritant effects are documented. Do not treat traditional mention as proof of safety.

Forms & dose

No self-use dose. Do not ingest latex or prepare home-made medicines. Only under supervision of a qualified Vaidya, in processed form, if an authoritative indication is confirmed.

Formulations

Processing and formulation details must be verified in authoritative texts. No home preparation instructions are provided.

Safety

Latex may cause eye injury, skin irritation, vomiting, and cardiac toxicity. Avoid contact with eyes and mouth. If swallowed or exposed to eyes, seek urgent medical care and do not induce vomiting.

Sources

Botanical identity: Kew Plants of the World Online (Calotropis species); toxicology literature on cardenolides and latex exposure.

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Suspected poisoning requires urgent professional/emergency care.

Yellow Oleander

Cascabela thevetia (L.) Lippold (syn. Thevetia peruviana)

TOXIC / HIGH-RISK MATERIAL — NO SELF-USE
Only under supervision of a qualified Vaidya, in processed form where applicable. Never ingest raw material or homemade preparations.

Part used: All parts, especially seeds | Family: Apocynaceae | EXTREMELY TOXIC.

Definition & scope

Yellow oleander is an ornamental plant whose seeds, leaves, and other parts contain cardiac glycosides. This entry is for recognition and safety only.

Constituents

Cardiac glycosides including thevetin-related compounds are reported; exposure can disrupt heart rhythm.

Traditional indications

No traditional use is recommended here. Do not use yellow oleander in any home remedy or medicinal preparation.

Benefits & evidence

Poisoning risk is severe and well established; there is no self-treatment benefit that justifies ingestion.

Forms & dose

No medicinal dose. Never chew, swallow, grind, or brew any part of the plant.

Formulations

No formulation or processing instructions are provided. Keep seeds, leaves, and plant debris away from children and animals.

Safety

Can cause nausea, vomiting, dangerous arrhythmias, fainting, and death. Any suspected ingestion is an emergency: call emergency services/poison control immediately; do not induce vomiting.

Sources

Botanical identity: Kew Plants of the World Online (Cascabela thevetia); clinical toxicology references on cardiac glycoside poisoning.

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Suspected poisoning requires urgent professional/emergency care.

Oleander

Nerium oleander L.

TOXIC / HIGH-RISK MATERIAL — NO SELF-USE
Only under supervision of a qualified Vaidya, in processed form where applicable. Never ingest raw material or homemade preparations.

Part used: All parts | Family: Apocynaceae | EXTREMELY TOXIC.

Definition & scope

An ornamental shrub with toxic cardiac glycosides throughout the plant. It must never be consumed as tea, medicine, or food.

Constituents

Oleandrin and related cardiac glycosides are reported in leaves, flowers, stems, and other parts.

Traditional indications

No medicinal use is recommended in this monograph. Traditional claims do not justify ingesting this plant.

Benefits & evidence

Severe poisoning can occur; clinical efficacy does not justify self-use.

Forms & dose

No medicinal dose. Do not ingest or prepare any part of the plant.

Formulations

No formulation instructions are provided. Do not burn or brew plant material for inhalation or ingestion.

Safety

May cause vomiting, abdominal pain, bradycardia or other arrhythmias, confusion, and death. Suspected exposure requires immediate emergency evaluation; do not induce vomiting.

Sources

Botanical identity: Kew Plants of the World Online (Nerium oleander); toxicology references on oleandrin and cardiac glycoside poisoning.

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Suspected poisoning requires urgent professional/emergency care.

Kupilu (Nux-vomica)

Strychnos nux-vomica L.

TOXIC / HIGH-RISK MATERIAL — NO SELF-USE
Only under supervision of a qualified Vaidya, in processed form where applicable. Never ingest raw material or homemade preparations.

Part used in historical materia medica: processed seed | Family: Loganiaceae | TOXIC / SHODHANA REQUIRED.

Definition & scope

A highly toxic plant associated with strychnine-containing seeds. The name Kupilu/Kuchla is used in traditional sources, but raw seed is dangerous.

Constituents

Seeds contain strychnine and brucine, potent neurotoxic alkaloids.

Traditional indications

Classical sources describe processed use in selected formulations; this monograph does not recommend self-treatment or provide a dose.

Benefits & evidence

Severe toxicity is established. Evidence does not support unsupervised use for any condition.

Forms & dose

No self-use dose. Only under supervision of a qualified Vaidya, in processed form. Never use raw seeds or homemade preparations.

Formulations

Any classical shodhana or formulation must be verified from an authoritative text and performed by qualified professionals; no instructions are provided.

Safety

Can cause painful muscle spasms, rigidity, seizures, respiratory failure, and death. Suspected ingestion is an emergency; seek immediate medical care and do not induce vomiting.

Sources

Botanical identity: Kew Plants of the World Online (Strychnos nux-vomica); toxicology literature on strychnine and brucine.

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Suspected poisoning requires urgent professional/emergency care.

Ativisha

Aconitum heterophyllum Wall. ex Royle

TOXIC / HIGH-RISK MATERIAL — NO SELF-USE
Only under supervision of a qualified Vaidya, in processed form where applicable. Never ingest raw material or homemade preparations.

Part used: Root | Family: Ranunculaceae | Identity caution: Must not be confused with highly toxic Aconitum species such as Vatsanabha.

Definition & scope

Aconitum heterophyllum is a traditional Ayurvedic plant name, distinct from several highly toxic aconite species. Authentication is essential because confusion or substitution can be dangerous.

Constituents

Reported constituents include diterpenoid alkaloids; the chemical profile and toxicity differ by species and plant material.

Traditional indications

Traditionally described in digestive and fever-related formulations. Persistent fever, dehydration, or serious illness requires medical assessment rather than self-treatment.

Benefits & evidence

Clinical evidence for specific benefits is limited. Species-specific identity and safety must be confirmed; data for one Aconitum species cannot be generalized to another.

Forms & dose

Traditional root preparations are described, but no standardized self-use dose is supplied. Use only authenticated products under qualified professional guidance.

Formulations

Formulation details must be verified in authoritative Ayurvedic references. Do not collect wild material or substitute other Aconitum species.

Safety

Incorrect identification or substitution with toxic aconites can cause severe poisoning, including dangerous heart rhythm disturbances and neurological symptoms. If exposure is suspected, seek emergency care immediately.

Sources

Botanical identity: Kew Plants of the World Online (Aconitum heterophyllum); current pharmacognosy and toxicology references. Confirm species identity and safety before any medicinal use.

Safety note: Traditional use does not establish safety or efficacy. Suspected poisoning requires urgent professional/emergency care.

Evidence Strength Guide

How to read medicinal claims

Evidence levels in this guide are descriptive, not a formal GRADE assessment.

Overview

Traditional use: a practice recorded in a traditional system. It can guide research but does not by itself prove benefit or safety.

Key considerations

Preclinical evidence: laboratory or animal studies. These may suggest mechanisms but often do not predict whether a treatment works in people.

Traditional / clinical context

Clinical evidence: human studies. Study size, design, controls, product identity, and replication all matter.

Evidence interpretation

Systematic reviews and guidelines can summarize multiple studies, but conclusions still depend on the quality and relevance of the included evidence.

Practical guidance

Do not interpret phrases such as “antioxidant,” “anti-inflammatory,” or “studied for” as proof that a herb treats a disease.

Additional notes

Look for a clearly identified species, plant part, preparation, dose, comparator, outcome, adverse events, and independent replication.

Safety

Evidence labels in individual monographs are cautious summaries, not medical recommendations.

References & verification

Suggested reference framework: National Center for Complementary and Integrative Health (NCCIH) consumer and evidence resources; Cochrane methods guidance; GRADE working-group materials.

Botanical Identity & Common Names

Avoiding species substitution

One common name may refer to different plants in different regions; one plant may also have several common names.

Overview

Confirm the Latin binomial, author where available, family, plant part, and supplier authentication. Do not identify a medicinal plant from a vernacular name alone.

Key considerations

Closely related species can have different chemistry and toxicity. This is particularly important for Aconitum, Datura, Calotropis, and other high-risk genera.

Traditional / clinical context

Trade substitution, adulteration, contamination, and incorrect labeling can change both effectiveness and risk.

Evidence interpretation

Use authenticated reference specimens, qualified pharmacognosy support, and reputable quality systems when identity is clinically important.

Practical guidance

Do not forage for medicinal plants for ingestion based only on photos or online descriptions.

Additional notes

Products should identify the botanical species, plant part, extract type, batch, manufacturer, and relevant quality testing where applicable.

Safety

This guide flags identity-sensitive names, but it cannot authenticate any physical product.

References & verification

Suggested references: Kew Plants of the World Online; WHO guidance on quality control of herbal materials; relevant national pharmacopoeias.

Traditional Processing & Shodhana

Why processing claims need verification

Shodhana is a term used for certain traditional purification or processing procedures; the exact process varies by substance and authoritative source.

Overview

Do not assume that washing, heating, soaking, or a home remedy makes a toxic plant safe. Some toxins may remain or processing may be inconsistent.

Key considerations

Processing must be linked to a specific authenticated material, method, quality standard, and validated endpoint; a generic claim of “purified” is not enough.

Traditional / clinical context

High-risk substances must not be prepared at home. This guide intentionally omits recipes and step-by-step processing instructions for toxic materials.

Evidence interpretation

Do not infer that a classical mention supports modern self-treatment. Risk depends on species, dose, processing, product quality, and the person's circumstances.

Practical guidance

Only under supervision of a qualified Vaidya, in processed form. This wording does not replace toxicology review or emergency care.

Additional notes

Ask a qualified practitioner about the exact text, formulation, manufacturing standards, and monitoring plan; avoid products with unclear ingredients.

Safety

Suspected exposure to a toxic plant requires prompt emergency/poison advice; do not wait for traditional processing information.

References & verification

Suggested references: authoritative Ayurvedic pharmacopoeias/formularies and current toxicology literature; verify the exact monograph for each substance.

Herb–Medicine Interactions

A practical screening checklist

Herbs and supplements can change the effects of prescription medicines, over-the-counter drugs, and other supplements.

Overview

Before starting a product, list all medicines and supplements, including dose, frequency, and reason for use. Show the actual label to a pharmacist or clinician.

Key considerations

Particular caution is needed with anticoagulants/antiplatelets, diabetes medicines, blood-pressure medicines, sedatives, psychiatric medicines, anti-seizure medicines, and drugs with narrow therapeutic ranges.

Traditional / clinical context

Examples in this collection include garlic supplements and bleeding risk, Mucuna products and levodopa-related effects, sedating herbs and central nervous system depressants, and laxatives and electrolyte disturbances.

Evidence interpretation

These are screening concerns, not a complete interaction database. A lack of a listed interaction does not prove safety.

Practical guidance

Do not stop or reduce prescribed medicines to use a herb. Do not combine multiple new supplements at once.

Additional notes

Ask a pharmacist to check interactions for the exact species, extract, brand, and dose.

Safety

Seek urgent care for fainting, severe allergic reaction, unusual bleeding, severe confusion, chest symptoms, or suspected poisoning.

References & verification

Suggested references: NCCIH herb–drug interaction resources; official medicine labels; pharmacist-reviewed interaction databases.

Pregnancy, Breastfeeding & Children

Higher-risk groups

Safety data for many medicinal herbs are limited in pregnancy, breastfeeding, and children.

Overview

Do not assume that “natural,” food use, or traditional use means a concentrated extract is safe in pregnancy or for a child.

Key considerations

Some plants may affect uterine activity, hormones, blood pressure, blood glucose, alertness, or drug metabolism.

Traditional / clinical context

Do not give a child an adult dose scaled by weight unless a qualified clinician has specifically advised it.

Evidence interpretation

Use only when a qualified healthcare professional has reviewed the exact product, indication, dose, and relevant medical history.

Practical guidance

Be especially cautious with toxic plants, essential oils, laxatives, and multi-ingredient products of uncertain composition.

Additional notes

Keep seeds, berries, essential oils, and all medicinal products locked away from children and pets.

Safety

During pregnancy, breastfeeding, or pediatric use, avoid self-prescribing and verify every ingredient with a clinician or pharmacist.

References & verification

Suggested references: official product labeling; national medicines regulators; NCCIH safety guidance; pediatric poison-control resources.

Product Quality & Contamination

What a label can and cannot tell you

Herbal product quality includes identity, purity, strength, stability, and freedom from harmful contamination.

Overview

Potential concerns include substitution, undeclared pharmaceuticals, heavy metals, pesticides, microbes, mycotoxins, and residual solvents.

Key considerations

Prefer traceable products with manufacturer details, batch/lot number, expiry date, ingredient list, and credible quality testing.

Traditional / clinical context

Claims such as “100% natural,” “detox,” or “clinically proven” are not substitutes for independent evidence and quality assurance.

Evidence interpretation

An ingredient label alone cannot confirm species identity, concentration, or absence of contaminants.

Practical guidance

Do not use products with missing labels, unclear botanical names, broken seals, unusual appearance, or untraceable sellers.

Additional notes

Report suspected adverse effects or product quality concerns to a healthcare professional and the relevant regulator.

Safety

Do not assume two brands or formulations are interchangeable because the front label uses the same common name.

References & verification

Suggested references: WHO quality-control guidance for herbal materials; national pharmacopoeias and medicines regulators.

Dose, Preparation & Standardization

Why a single dose rarely fits every product

Herbal dose depends on species, plant part, extraction method, concentration, formulation, route, and patient factors.

Overview

A teaspoon of crude powder, a decoction, a tincture, and a concentrated extract are not equivalent exposures.

Key considerations

Different batches can vary in active constituents. Some high-risk plants have no appropriate self-use dose and are intentionally not assigned one in this guide.

Traditional / clinical context

Do not copy a dose from an unrelated species, a social-media post, or a product with a different extract ratio.

Evidence interpretation

Follow the exact licensed product label or the advice of a qualified clinician/pharmacist for products where medicinal use is appropriate.

Practical guidance

Do not exceed the label, combine multiple products with the same ingredients, or use laxatives for weight loss.

Additional notes

Standardization may improve consistency but does not automatically establish clinical effectiveness or safety.

Safety

Record product name, batch, dose, start date, and any adverse symptoms if a clinician has approved use.

References & verification

Suggested references: official product monographs, pharmacopoeias, WHO herbal medicine quality guidance, and clinical references.

Recognizing Adverse Reactions

When to stop and seek help

Possible adverse effects range from mild digestive symptoms or rash to severe allergic reactions, bleeding, organ injury, or poisoning.

Overview

Stop the suspected product and seek professional advice if a new symptom appears after starting it; do not rechallenge a severe reaction.

Key considerations

Emergency warning signs include trouble breathing, swelling of the tongue or throat, collapse, seizure, severe confusion, chest pain, severe bleeding, or suspected ingestion of a toxic plant.

Traditional / clinical context

Do not induce vomiting or try to neutralize a poison with food, drink, or another herb unless emergency professionals instruct you.

Evidence interpretation

Take the package, label, plant photo, or remaining material to the emergency department if it is safe to do so.

Practical guidance

Do not wait for symptoms after suspected exposure to highly toxic plants such as oleander, yellow oleander, Datura, Vatsanabha/aconite, Gunja, or Kupilu.

Additional notes

Use your local emergency number or poison information service; in India, call 112 for emergency assistance where available.

Safety

Report suspected adverse effects to a clinician and relevant medicines regulator.

References & verification

Suggested references: local emergency/poison services; official regulator adverse-event reporting guidance; clinical toxicology resources.

Glossary of Ayurvedic Terms

Reading traditional terminology carefully

Dravya: a substance or material; in this guide, usually a plant-derived medicinal material.

Overview

Rasa, guna, virya, and vipaka are traditional descriptive frameworks concerning taste, qualities, potency, and post-digestive effect. They are not direct equivalents of modern pharmacological measures.

Key considerations

Anupana: a vehicle or accompanying substance used with a preparation in a traditional context.

Traditional / clinical context

Churna: powder; kwatha/kashaya: decoction; taila: oil; ghrita: ghee-based preparation; arishta/asava: fermented preparations. Actual compositions vary.

Evidence interpretation

Rasayana is a broad traditional category associated with rejuvenation or support; it should not be interpreted as a proven anti-aging or disease-prevention claim.

Practical guidance

Visha/Upavisha are traditional categories associated with poisonous or toxic substances in some Ayurvedic texts; exact classification should be verified in authoritative sources.

Additional notes

Shodhana refers to traditional processing or purification procedures in specific contexts; it does not guarantee safety unless the exact material and process are validated.

Safety

Traditional terminology can guide interpretation but should not be used as a substitute for modern diagnosis, toxicology, or clinical evidence.

References & verification

Suggested references: recognized Ayurvedic dictionaries, pharmacopoeias, and formularies; verify terminology and substance-specific classifications.

Bibliography & Verification Policy

How references should be checked

Botanical names and synonyms should be checked against a recognized taxonomic resource such as Kew Plants of the World Online.

Overview

Safety statements should be checked against poison-control, regulator, clinical toxicology, and official product-label sources whenever possible.

Key considerations

Traditional indications and formulations should be traced to a named authoritative Ayurvedic text, pharmacopoeia, or formulary, including edition and page where available.

Traditional / clinical context

Clinical claims should be checked against controlled human studies, systematic reviews, and current professional guidance—not only laboratory experiments or marketing pages.

Evidence interpretation

Where a reliable dose or reference could not be confirmed, this project uses cautious wording such as “not established” rather than inventing a value.

Practical guidance

Some earlier individual monographs use general reference descriptions rather than full formal citations; before publication or clinical use, replace these with edition/page-level references.

Additional notes

Verify taxonomy changes and synonyms at the time of publication, because accepted names can change.

Safety

Do not treat this collection as a validated prescribing formulary or a substitute for practitioner assessment.

References & verification

Reference framework: Kew Plants of the World Online; WHO herbal quality-control guidance; NCCIH; national pharmacopoeias and formularies; peer-reviewed clinical and toxicology literature.